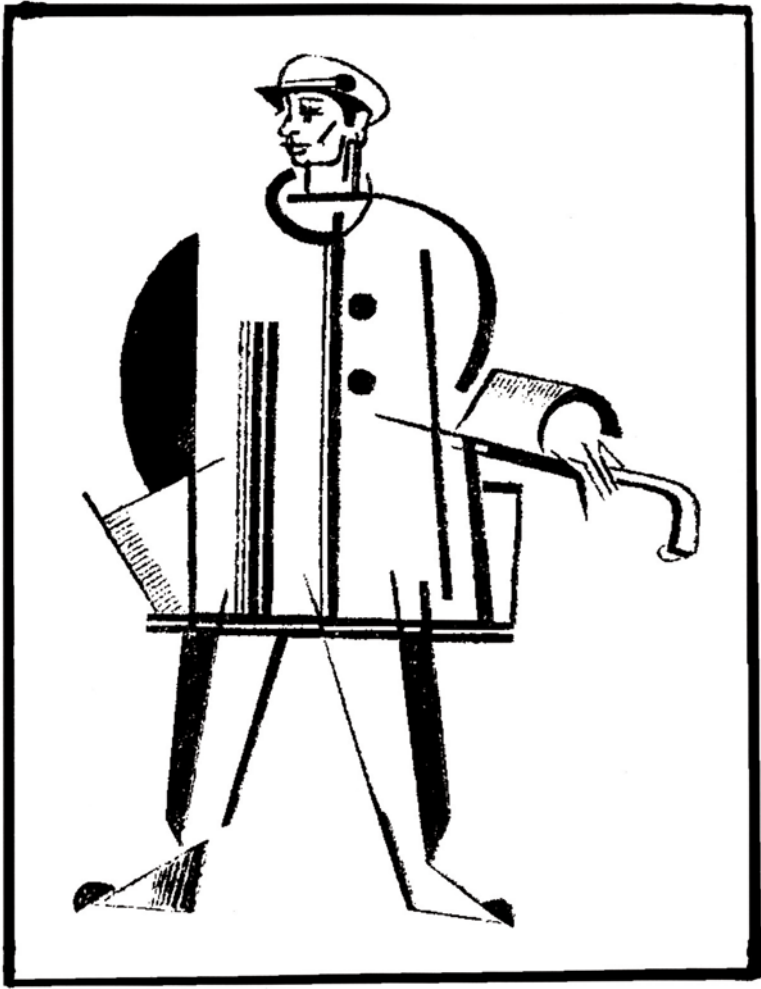


The Major Plays of Nikolai Erdman



The Warrant and The Suicide

translated and edited by
John Freedman

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THE WARRANT

Characters

Nadézhda Petróvna Gulyáchkina
Pável Sergéyevich Gulyáchkin, her son (also called Pavlúsha)
Varvára Sergéyevna Gulyáchkina, her daughter (also called Várya)
Iván Ivánovich Shirónkin, their lodger
Anastásiya Nikolájevna Púpkina, the Gulyachkin's cook (also called Nástya)
Tamára Leopóldovna Lishnévskaya
Olímp Valeriánovich Smetánich
Valerián Olímpovich Smetánich, his son
Anatóly Olímpovich Smetánich, his youngest son
Avtonóm Sigismúndovich
Agafángel, his servant
Stepán Stepánovich
Felitsiáta Gordéyevna, his wife
Ilínkin
Ilínkina
Zótik Frántsevich Zarkhín
Ariádna Pavlínovna Zarkhiná, his wife
Tósya, their daughter
Syúsya, their daughter
Narkís Smarágdovich Krántik
Father Pavsikákhy
A Janitor
A Hurdy-Gurdy Man
A Drummer
A Woman with a Parrot and Tambourine
A Cabby
Guests

ACT I

SCENE ONE

(A room in the Gulyachkin apartment. Pavel stands on a step-ladder hanging paintings. His mother Nadezhda stands beside him. On the floor next to her are framed paintings)

PAVEL. All right now, mother, hand me "Evening in Copenhagen."

NADEZHDA. No, Pavlusha, I think it should be "I Believe in Thee, O Lord."

PAVEL. No, mama, "Evening in Copenhagen" will be more artistic.

NADEZHDA. Well, you know best, Pavlusha. Only I definitely wanted to hang "I Believe in Thee, O Lord" in the middle. It has a prettier frame, Pavlusha. And its content is more profound than "Evening in Copenhagen."

PAVEL. As for the content, mama, take a look at it from another point of view.

NADEZHDA. *(Looking at the other side)* Oh my God! Who is that?

PAVEL. No need to be so frightened, mama. These aren't the old days anymore.

NADEZHDA. Whose mug did you stick on here, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. Read what it says, mama.

NADEZHDA. Hmm. I knew right away he wasn't a Russian. *(Turns the painting around. It is a portrait of Karl Marx)* What's got into you, Pavlusha? These pictures hung side by side for eighteen years. They were pleasing to look at and they never offended a soul.

PAVEL. Mama, you reason like an unconscious element. For example, mama, what, in your opinion, is a picture?

NADEZHDA. How should I know, Pavlusha? I don't read the newspapers.

PAVEL. No, I want you to tell me, mama. In your opinion, what is a picture?

NADEZHDA. In the old days, Pavlusha, there was a post-office clerk who used to take his meals with us. And he always used to say, "Listen here, Nadezhda Petrovna, a picture is nothing but a cry of the soul and a pleasure for the sensory organs."

PAVEL. Maybe that's how it used to be, but these days a picture is nothing but a tool of propaganda.

NADEZHDA. A tool? What do you mean?

PAVEL. It's very simple. Let's say some representative of authority comes to visit us and we have "I Believe in Thee, O Lord" hanging on the wall. A picture like that makes people ask questions. And so he asks, "What did

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your great-grandfather do, citizeness Gulyachkina?"

NADEZHDA. He didn't do anything. He was the owner of an establishment.

PAVEL. What kind of establishment?

NADEZHDA. A laundry.

PAVEL. A what?

NADEZHDA. A laundry, I said.

PAVEL. A laundry? And what if I arrest you for such bourgeois prejudices?

NADEZHDA. Lord Almighty!

PAVEL. You got that right.

NADEZHDA. How is an honest person supposed to live in the world?

PAVEL. You have to be sneaky, mama. Real sneaky. Don't you pay any mind that I never finished high-school. I see right through this whole revolution.

NADEZHDA. It's a shady business, Pavlusha. You think you can see through it?

PAVEL. Just look through the peep-hole, mama. Look through the peep-hole.

NADEZHDA. The peep-hole? What peep-hole, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. As you know, mama, we have a frosted-glass window in the entryway. So I drilled a hole in it.

NADEZHDA. What did you do that for?

PAVEL. What for? Let's say, for example, somebody rings the doorbell. So you peek through the peep-hole and you see who's come for what. Let's say, for example, it's the chairman of the housing committee, or what's worse, some police commissar.

NADEZHDA. Oh! Lord have mercy on us!

PAVEL. No need for that, mama. As soon as you see some visitor like that through the peep-hole, you immediately turn over the picture and politely usher him into the dining room.

NADEZHDA. And then what?

PAVEL. The commissar will stand there a few minutes and then go away.

NADEZHDA. Why is that, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. Because Karl Marx is the highest boss they've got, mama.

NADEZHDA. You thought it all through wonderfully. Only this man's mug, so to speak, ruins the whole atmosphere of the room.

PAVEL. Don't worry, mama. Whenever we have decent guests, we can turn the picture over and show "Evening in Copenhagen." That way, even if Mister Smetanich himself were to come, he'd say we're not revolutionaries of some sort, but that we're cultured people.

NADEZHDA. In fact, you know what, Pavlusha? Mister Smetanich promised to pay us a visit today.

PAVEL. Why did he do that?

NADEZHDA. No reason. He just said, "I'll come take a look at your son and see how you live."

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PAVEL. Why didn't you tell me before, mama? Amazing. Quick, I'll hang up "I Believe in Thee, O Lord." Here, help me move the step-ladder. Is that really what he said, mama? That he wants to take a look at your son?

NADEZHDA. That's what he said.

PAVEL. I don't care what you say, mama, but for an occasion like this I'm putting on a new pair of pants.

NADEZHDA. Wait a minute. I haven't told you yet that Mister Smetanich wants to marry his son to Varya.

PAVEL. Varya?

NADEZHDA. Yes.

PAVEL. His son and Varya?

NADEZHDA. Yes.

PAVEL. Excuse me, mama, but I think your health is failing or perhaps you're sick.

NADEZHDA. No. God is merciful.

PAVEL. But mama, how can he want to marry his son to Varya when he's never even seen our Varya?

NADEZHDA. You think that's bad?

PAVEL. I'm not saying anything, mama. Maybe it would be worse yet if he had seen her. But, somehow, I just can't believe it.

NADEZHDA. You should believe when people tell you things.

PAVEL. Are you telling me, mama, that we're soon going to be relatives of Mister Smetanich?

NADEZHDA. Don't rush things. You should think about the dowry first.

PAVEL. The dowry? Then nothing will come of it, mama. You know yourself that we're bankrupt people.

NADEZHDA. He's not asking for money, Pavlusha.

PAVEL. What does he want then, mama?

NADEZHDA. A fatted calf, my dear.

PAVEL. What do you mean, a fatted calf?

NADEZHDA. The fact is, Pavlusha, he's asking for a communist as Varya's dowry.

PAVEL. A communist?

NADEZHDA. Well, yes.

PAVEL. But mama, how can you offer a live party member as a dowry?

NADEZHDA. Well, you obviously can't just grab one off the street. But if he's one of your own, let's say, a member of the family, I don't see that anyone can forbid that.

PAVEL. Mama, we're good Christians. We don't keep communists here.

NADEZHDA. Don't worry, son. Don't worry, Pavlusha. I'll atone for your sin.

PAVEL. What sin?

NADEZHDA. Well, Pavlusha, you're going to have to join the Party.

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PAVEL. Me? Join the Party?

NADEZHDA. You, my dear, you. Pavlusha, Mister Smetanich is counting on you.

PAVEL. Mama, hold on to the step-ladder because everything just went black before my eyes.

NADEZHDA. Just think about it, Pavlusha. We'll marry off Varya, I'll go live with Mister Smetanich and before you know it, I'll have educated grandchildren running all around me.

PAVEL. But mama, what am I going to do?

NADEZHDA. What's there to do? People in authority don't do anything. Just ride around in your automobile. Imagine, Pavlusha, you'll start riding around in your automobile and I'll start praying for you. You go for a spin and I'll pray, you go for a spin and I'll pray. Oh, what a life it will be!

PAVEL. Go for a ride? Well all right, mama. I'll think about it. (*Hammers in a nail*)

NADEZHDA. You think about it, Pavlusha! Think about it!

(*Pavel hammers in another nail*)

Oh yes, I also wanted to tell you....

PAVEL. Don't interrupt me, mama. I'm thinking. Ah! I always wanted to be a boss of some kind! As soon as something happened somewhere—wham!—I'd slam the table with my fist. "Silence!" (*Misses the nail head and whacks the wall with his hammer. The sound of falling pots and pans is heard*) There's silence for you.

NADEZHDA. Oh, my Lord! I hope that wasn't our boarder's pots.

SCENE TWO

(*Ivan runs into the room with a shriek. On his head is an overturned pot*)

IVAN. Help! Help! Help, citizens! I'm drowning!

PAVEL. What happened?

IVAN. Ah, so there you are! You'll answer for this, citizen. Rest assured. I'll have justice, citizen.

PAVEL. What right do you have to go around shouting in family surroundings?

IVAN. What do you expect me to do when you try drowning a live man in milk and macaroni?

PAVEL. Excuse me...

IVAN. I certainly will not.

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SCENE THREE

(Enter Varvara)

VARVARA. What's the ruckus?

NADEZHDA. What's the problem, Ivan Ivanovich? What happened?

IVAN. Nadezhda Petrovna, how many times have I told you that I am an intellectual laborer? And here you go hammering nails into the wall on purpose.

NADEZHDA. Pardon me, but your nails are no business of ours and our nails are no business of yours. We are in our own room, here.

IVAN. However, Nadezhda Petrovna, I prepare my own meals...

NADEZHDA. Incidentally, the whole house stinks from your meals.

IVAN. I'm sorry, but I'm a bachelor. And unlike some people I know, I don't have any live-in girlfriends to help me. All I have is a paraffin stove. I do have to eat, you know.

NADEZHDA. You might hold your tongue about who lives with you and who doesn't. My daughter is a virgin, you know.

VARVARA. Oh, mother. Don't exaggerate.

IVAN. You expect me to hold my tongue when all I have left over from dinner is some milk and macaroni and you go and knock it over on my head? I'm supposed to keep silent about that, am I?

NADEZHDA. We can't be responsible for your macaroni.

IVAN. Oh, is that right? But you can hammer on the wall as long as it takes for all my pots and pans to fall on my head. What if I had drowned to death in this macaroni? Who would be responsible for that? You or me?

NADEZHDA. If you were a cockroach, Ivan Ivanovich, that would be one thing. But people don't drown in macaroni.

IVAN. The police will tell you whether they do or don't. Rest assured, I won't leave this matter unreported.

NADEZHDA. Ivan Ivanovich, do I look like a criminal or something that you should go around reporting me to the police?

VARVARA. Ivan Ivanovich, you ought to take that pot off your head. It doesn't make a very becoming hat.

IVAN. Oh no you don't. I'm not taking it off. Take it off now and then just try to prove it used to be on your head. No way. I'll tell the commissar, "Look here, comrade commissar, this is hard evidence that the public peace and quiet has been violated." You can call it a pot if you want, but I call it evidence.

NADEZHDA. Are you telling me that you're going to go out on the street with this evidence on your head?

IVAN. I am.

NADEZHDA. They'll put you in an insane asylum.

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IVAN. We live in a free society these days. All the insane asylums are closed.

NADEZHDA. Pavlusha, scream something at him please.

PAVEL. How can I scream something at him, mama, when he has such an unpleasant character?

NADEZHDA. Go on, Pavlusha. Don't be afraid, my dear. Otherwise he really will go to the police.

IVAN. Nadezhda Petrovna, I don't advise you to whisper with your son. I am not afraid of your son, Nadezhda Petrovna. I'm not afraid of anybody on earth, Nadezhda Petrovna. I, Nadezhda Petrovna...

PAVEL. Silence! I'm a party man!

(Everyone, beginning with Pavel, is horrified. Ivan begins backing up towards the door and then leaves)

SCENE FOUR

PAVEL. Mama, I'm leaving for the provinces.

VARVARA. What do you mean, you're leaving?

NADEZHDA. What are you leaving for?

PAVEL. Because they can shoot you for saying words like that, mama.

VARVARA and NADEZHDA. Shoot you?

NADEZHDA. Pavlusha, there is no such law that says you can shoot a man for the words he says.

PAVEL. Not all words are equal, mama.

NADEZHDA. I heard all kinds of words when your father was still alive. The late Sergei Tarasych used to say such words that you can't even repeat them in front of an unmarried person. But when he died, it was vodka that killed him, and you tell me...

VARVARA. Mama, don't change the subject. That's not only absurd, it's silly.

PAVEL. But mama, I haven't joined the Party yet.

NADEZHDA. Well then, join.

PAVEL. There's not much I can do about it now. I'll have to.

NADEZHDA. Thank God! Then we can throw a wedding soon. Varvara, thank your brother. He agreed.

VARVARA. *(Extending her hand)* Merci.

PAVEL. But what if they don't take me, mama?

NADEZHDA. Oh, come now, Pavlusha. They take all kinds of derelicts.

PAVEL. In that case, mama, do you know Utkin?

NADEZHDA. You mean the one who crashed his airplane?

PAVEL. That's Utochkin, mama. I'm talking about Utkin.¹

¹ Sergei Utochkin was a pioneer in Russian aviation. Utkin is a humorous name that sounds like Mr. Duck.

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NADEZHDA. Then I don't know him.

PAVEL. I met him back when I travelled by train to Samara to buy some bread. To look at him, mama, you'd think he's perfectly normal, but, in fact, he has three relatives who are party members. So here's what I'm going to do, mama. I'm going to invite him over here. Maybe they'll give me a recommendation to get me in the Party.

NADEZHDA. That's a good idea, Pavlusha. Invite them over.

PAVEL. I should also tell you, mama, that if they find out we used to own a grocery store we could wind up in all kinds of trouble.

NADEZHDA. How would they find out about that, Pavlusha? They won't find out.

PAVEL. I just mention it so that you'll be sure to serve them up a hospitable dose of politics.

NADEZHDA. I fixed a sturgeon pie for today, Pavlusha. We can serve them that.

PAVEL. Are you crazy, mama? Do you think communists eat sturgeon? The next thing you'll suggest is crème brûlée or something. We have to show them our Spartan living conditions, and you go suggesting sturgeon pie. And one more thing, mama. In general, if I'm going to be a sacrificial lamb in this family, I demand that everyone here fear me.

NADEZHDA. But, Pavlush...

PAVEL. Silence! For the last time in my life, mama, I demand that, by this evening, all soups in our home be of a proletarian origin. No more "Copenhagens," you got that?

NADEZHDA. Yes, Pavlusha.

PAVEL. And if Varvara says even one more word about God or grocery stores, as God is my witness, I'm heading for the provinces.

VARVARA. This is all rather odd.

PAVEL. That's enough opposition from you, Varvara. One might say that, because of you, a young man at the height of his powers has been reduced to a dowry. You've got no business turning your nose up at him.

NADEZHDA. Varya, ask your brother's forgiveness right now.

VARVARA. But mama...

NADEZHDA. Varvara.

VARVARA. But ma...

NADEZHDA. Varya.

VARVARA. Sorry.

PAVEL. Well, all right then. I'm going now.

NADEZHDA. Where are you going, Pavlusha? To see Utkin?

PAVEL. Yes, mama, to see... Oh my God. I'm done for.

NADEZHDA. What's wrong, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. How can I invite him to visit us when we don't have a single relative from the working class?

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NADEZHDA. You know I never refuse you anything, Pavlusha, but what we don't have, we don't have.

PAVEL. What if we put over some friends as relatives, mama? Listen, Varya, do you have any friends from the working class?

VARVARA. Maybe I don't even run around with office workers, let alone the working class.

PAVEL. What are we going to do, mama?

NADEZHDA. Wait a minute. Let's ask Nastya. Nastya! Nastya! Oh that little reprobate. She's probably buried in a book again. Nastya!

PAVEL. Varvara, are you deaf or something? Your own mother is screaming her head off and you sit there like a bump on a log.

VARVARA. Shouting is bad for me. My music teacher discovered I'm a coloratura soprano.

PAVEL. Then you can stay a soprano virgin if you want.

NADEZHDA. Do you want to ruin the whole thing? Shout when you're told to shout.

VARVARA. Nastya!

PAVEL. Wow, Varvara! What an incredibly disgusting voice you have.

VARVARA. Disgusting? My music teacher told me...

PAVEL. Your music teacher is an idiot. Nastya!

ALL. Nastya!

VOICE OF NASTYA. Here I am!

ALL. Ah!

SCENE FIVE

(Enter Nastya, the Gulyachkin's cook)

NADEZHDA. What are you shouting about? What are you shouting about, I ask you? Huh? You're in my home, not out on the street somewhere.

NASTYA. I...

NADEZHDA. Shut up when you're being spoken to. You should have been born a foot soldier and not a cook.

NASTYA. I...

NADEZHDA. Don't talk back to me. How come you don't hear us when we're shouting at you? Huh? Are you reading books again? Do you think I pay you so that you can go around buying books all the time?

PAVEL. Mama, settle down. Nastya, I wanted to ask you whether you happen to have any visitors from the working class.

NASTYA. Pavel Sergeyevich! I am a lady.

PAVEL. That's not what I'm talking about. I am asking whether you happen to have acquaintances from the working class.

NASTYA. Unmarried gentlewomen don't have acquaintances.

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NADEZHDA. Don't lie to us, Nastya.

NASTYA. Nadezhda Petrovna, I have served many masters and no one has ever observed me with acquaintances. You can run a check if you like.

NADEZHDA. Nastya, I'm telling you, don't lie to us.

NASTYA. Nadezhda Petrovna, if you're talking about Ivan Ivanovich, he's not even a man, he's just a boarder.

NADEZHDA. What?

NASTYA. And even if he did invite me to his room, that was purely for the purposes of enlarging my bust.

PAVEL. For what?

NASTYA. For enlarging my bust.

NADEZHDA. Nastya, you've gone off your rocker. I am preparing to give away my lawful daughter in marriage and, right here in my home, you engage in depravity. Do you think I pay you so that you can go around enlarging your bust? Huh?

VARVARA. Leave her alone, please, mama. This is interesting. Tell me, Nastya, is he really able to enlarge it?

NASTYA. Yes.

VARVARA. How does he do it?

NASTYA. I don't really know how he does it. He suggested it himself. You know, when I lived on Three Saints Lane there was a photography studio located just across the way. It was called "Electric Chic." Naturally, I went over to this "Electric Chic" and ordered half a dozen photos for my own personal enjoyment. But as you know yourself, mademoiselle, the photos they make there are tiny. Your face on them only shows up down to your waist. And since Ivan Ivanovich is a man with what you might call a photographic education, he said to me just yesterday, "Anastasiya Nikolayevna, if you want, I'll enlarge your bust."

VARVARA. You idiot. I got my hopes up for nothing.

NADEZHDA. What kind of nonsense is this? Get out of here right now. Go to the kitchen.

(Nastya leaves)

SCENE SIX

NADEZHDA. Oh, how that girl makes me suffer! Nobody has enough nerves to put up with what I've put up with.

PAVEL. At the present moment, mama, that is a question of secondary importance. You'd be better off telling me what I'm going to do about the relatives I don't have.

VARVARA. You've got a one-track mind. Can't you talk about anything but relatives?

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PAVEL. One-track mind? Is that what you said? A one-track mind? I am asking you, did you say I have a one-track mind?

VARVARA. Naturally.

PAVEL. All right Varvara. Here is my ultimatum. Until you find me some relatives from the working class, you can stay a virgin. That's one.

VARVARA. Where am I supposed to find them, Pavel?

PAVEL. I repeat in no uncertain terms, that's one. And your boarder who enlarges busts for other people's cooks, you can just get him out of here. I have no intentions of remaining under one roof with him. That's two.

VARVARA. You really mean get rid of him, Pavel?

PAVEL. Are you saying you won't do it?

VARVARA. Absolutely.

PAVEL. And I say that's two and bye-bye baby. (*Goes out*)

SCENE SEVEN

NADEZHDA. Do as you like, Varvara, but you're going to have to find him some relatives.

VARVARA. He's gotten too big for his britches, mama.

NADEZHDA. Varvara, are you saying that you can't put a little effort into your own happiness? Or do you think that you're the only bride left on earth? Huh?

VARVARA. All right, mama. I'll look for some. That's one. But as for two, how are we going to get rid of him?

NADEZHDA. With noise I think, Varya. With noise.

VARVARA. Noise?

NADEZHDA. Well, yes. You know yourself, Varya, that Ivan Ivanovich can't stand noise. So we'll drive him out with noise.

VARVARA. What noise, mama?

NADEZHDA. That's easy. We can play games of some sort, dance, sing. For instance, if you were to sing him something today, maybe he'd leave right away.

VARVARA. What do you think I am, mama? Chaliapin? I don't even have the voice for that. You'd be better off telling me, mama, is he a brunette?

NADEZHDA. Who? Chaliapin?

VARVARA. No, mama. I mean Mister Smetanich's son.

NADEZHDA. On the contrary. He has brown hair.

VARVARA. Oh, what a shame.

NADEZHDA. How come?

VARVARA. Because blonde women look good when their husbands are brunettes.

NADEZHDA. Are you planning to live with somebody's hair or with a man?

VARVARA. It's a matter of taste, mama. And there's no accounting for taste.

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By the way, mama, I literally have no idea what his name is.
NADEZHDA. His name is Valerian, Varya. Valerian Olimpovich Smetanich.
VARVARA. I think Valerian is a wonderful name. Only it sounds a little bit like sleeping pills or something. But basically I'm satisfied.
NADEZHDA. I would hope so. Satisfied isn't the word. Any conscious lady would give her eye tooth to sink her teeth into a man like Valerian Olimpovich. What a soul he has, Varya! What a build he has, Varya! And what a father! Oh, what a father! Just imagine, Varya. This man has been going bankrupt ever since the revolution started, and he still hasn't been able to go bankrupt all the way. It's a wonder the earth can hold a man like that. People of his kind ought to be taken straight to heaven without dying.
VARVARA. What do you think, mama? Should I go to the hairdresser?
NADEZHDA. What for?
VARVARA. To get my hair curled, mama. Plus, I always smell good after I've been to the hairdresser.
NADEZHDA. Good idea, Varya. Go ahead, dear.
VARVARA. Only please don't you tell him anything, mama. Let him think I smell that way on my own. *(Leaves)*

SCENE EIGHT

NADEZHDA. Lord Almighty! Life? This isn't life. You give away your own daughter in marriage and you're seized by nothing but terror. You live in your own personal home and you have to pay rent for your apartment. Life? This isn't life. And people, look what people have turned into. Young girls aren't only having babies, they're smoking tobacco. And if it's not bad enough that men don't give up their seats to women on trolley cars anymore, they've even stopped doing it for priests. Life? This isn't life. And then look what they've done with the church. In peacetime you could buy a candle for three kopecks and pray as long as your heart desired. And now they say they're going to start taxing every prayerful person for every prayer they utter. At that rate, an all-night service will bankrupt me. They've got another thing coming, though. A true believer can always find a way to pray for free. *(During her monologue, Nadezhda spreads out a clean cloth on the table and puts a grammophone on it. She lights candles at either side of the grammophone)* It's not for nothing that in the Kireev sons' eighty-sixth Psalm it's written in plain black and white, "Singers and dancers alike say, 'All my springs are in you.'" *(She puts on a record and kneels. The music is from a vespers service)* Truly is it said, let every breath give praise to God. Lord, Lord, hear his sinner.

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SCENE NINE

(Enter Nastya)

NASTYA. Madame.

NADEZHDA. Ah! You idiot. You're always sneaking up on me during my prayers.

NASTYA. Madame, some lady is asking for you.

NADEZHDA. What lady?

NASTYA. I've never seen her. However, here she is herself.

SCENE TEN

(Enter Tamara)

NADEZHDA. Is that you, Tamara Leopoldovna? Come in, come in, please.

Lord Almighty, what a pleasant surprise. Nastya, stop the service.

TAMARA. Bring it in. Bring it right in here.

SCENE ELEVEN

(Two men carry in a trunk)

NADEZHDA. Heavens! Are you moving in with me Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. Oh, don't ask, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. Oh, I don't understand, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. Oh, it's simply awful, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. Oh, you're frightening me, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. Oh, don't speak about it, Nadezhda Petrovna. Put it right here.

That's it. I won't be needing you any more.

NADEZHDA. Nastya, show these men the door.

(Nastya and the two men leave)

SCENE TWELVE

NADEZHDA. Sit down, sit down, Tamara Leopoldovna. Not there, not there, Tamara Leopoldovna. Right here in the easy chair with the little pillow.

TAMARA. Oh, it makes no difference.

NADEZHDA. How is your health, Tamara Leopoldovna? Are you feeling well?

TAMARA. Can't you see for yourself that I'm not myself at all?

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NADEZHDA. Heavens! Don't tell me you've had some misfortune.

TAMARA. Oh, what a nightmare. Oh, what a nightmare. Just imagine, Nadezhda Petrovna, we are expecting a search this evening.

NADEZHDA. A search? In the Lord's name, may they all be damned. How can it possibly be, Tamara Leopoldovna, that someone would up and want to search such a fine woman as you, Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. You don't really think that men are capable of appreciating a fine woman, do you, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. What are these accursed people planning to search you for?

TAMARA. You're so naive, Nadezhda Petrovna. It's obvious for what. Does anybody need a reason to do anything any more? I could understand it, Nadezhda Petrovna, if my husband were serving in the organs. I don't deny it, it's true that in the course of service one can occasionally..., oh, what do you call it? One can occasionally spring a leak, or something. You know, a slip of the pen or the tongue, or something like that. But I repeat, Nadezhda Petrovna, my husband doesn't serve anywhere at all. And now it turns out that you can't live and not serve the organs. But, tell me this, if he has to serve, that means he has to work. And if he has to work, then how will he ever be able to earn a living?

NADEZHDA. Oh, life. This isn't life.

TAMARA. You're telling me. Such a great country, and—boom!—a revolution. One is simply ashamed before the other monarchies. Can such a dim-witted people really understand an idea? You know, Nadezhda Petrovna, my husband always said, "If they'd have a revolution a hundred years from now, I'd definitely support it."

NADEZHDA. What are you going to do now, Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. I have a favor to ask of you, Nadezhda Petrovna. Only I don't know whether you'll agree to it.

NADEZHDA. But of course, Tamara Leopoldovna. For you, Tamara Leopoldovna, I'd.... Why, you were once our best customer, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. In that case, take this trunk off my hands.

NADEZHDA. That's all?

TAMARA. Oh my, no. This trunk is very dangerous.

NADEZHDA. Dangerous?

TAMARA. Look here. (*Opens the trunk*)

NADEZHDA. A dress? I thought there was a bomb inside.

TAMARA. Oh, if only you knew whose dress this was, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. You mean it's not yours, Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. Oh, don't even ask, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. Oh, then whose is it, Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. Oh, don't even speak about it, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. Oh, you can tell me, Tamara Leopoldovna.

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TAMARA. Well then listen, Nadezhda Petrovna. This dress.... Close the door, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. There, it's closed, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. This dress... belonged to Alexandra Fyodorovna.

NADEZHDA. What Alexandra Fyodorovna? You mean the midwife Alexandra Fyodorovna who gave birth to my Pavlusha with me?

TAMARA. What midwife, Nadezhda Petrovna? I'm talking about the empress.

NADEZHDA. The emp.... Oh, Tamara Leopoldovna!

TAMARA. "Oh" is right, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. How did it fall into your hands, Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. Oh, it's a long story. Can you imagine it? In the old days my husband had an aunt. This aunt had a son who lived in Petersburg. And can you imagine it, a genuine lady-in-waiting was the godmother of the eldest daughter of the landlady of my husband's aunt's very own son. So when the terrible catastrophe took place, everyone began scrambling to save Russia. And her Excellency's lady-in-waiting, the godmother of the eldest daughter of the landlady of my husband's aunt's son, saved this dress. But since Russia didn't stop its hell-bent slide into ruin, the landlady of my husband's aunt's son, in her turn, was forced to save the dress for the lady-in-waiting. Then my husband's aunt's son saved the dress for the landlady, my husband's aunt saved it for her son, and finally, my husband saved it for his aunt. In short, if they find out that we saved this dress, we're doomed.

NADEZHDA. What a horrible story. You'd better get rid of it, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. You're crazy, Nadezhda Petrovna. Don't you realize, Nadezhda Petrovna, that this trunk contains everything that is left of Russia in Russia? And who can we count on to save Russia these days if not ourselves, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. That's true, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. And then, Nadezhda Petrovna, if the French are able to slip some sort of tsar into Russia in the near future, perhaps they'll give my husband a medal for saving this dress.

NADEZHDA. A medal? What sort of medal?

TAMARA. What sort? I don't know. Maybe an order of some kind or a small pension.

NADEZHDA. A pension? In that case, Tamara Leopoldovna, please don't forget to petition on our account.

TAMARA. How can you even ask, Nadezhda Petrovna? For heroism like this, we'll be happy to petition for you.

NADEZHDA. Oh, I'm just doing this for you, Tamara Leopoldovna.

TAMARA. Not for me, Nadezhda Petrovna. For Russia.

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NADEZHDA. Oh, when-oh-when will the old days return?

TAMARA. Just this morning, my husband said to me, "Tamara sweetheart, peek through the window, please, and tell me, has the Soviet state collapsed yet?" "No," I said to him, "It seems to be holding strong." "Oh well, Tamara dear," he said, "draw the curtains and we'll look again tomorrow."

NADEZHDA. But when will tomorrow come?

TAMARA. Patience, Nadezhda Petrovna, patience. And in the meantime, take this. *(Pulls out a pistol)*

NADEZHDA. Heavens! A pistol!

TAMARA. Don't be afraid, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. But what if it shoots?

TAMARA. If you don't touch it, Nadezhda Petrovna, it won't shoot. Even so, I'll feel safer for the dress's sake. And so guard it well and have faith in God.

NADEZHDA. I do have faith, Tamara Leopoldovna, I do have faith. But I don't know who you can have faith in anymore when, other than God, there are no good people left in Moscow.

TAMARA. Well, farewell, Nadezhda Petrovna. And remember, mum's the word.

NADEZHDA. I'll be as silent as the grave, Tamara Leopoldovna. God be with you.

(Tamara leaves)

SCENE THIRTEEN

NADEZHDA. Lord Almighty! Lord Almighty! Life? This isn't life. Well, I'll just finish praying now and then I'll look to see if the sturgeon pie is ready. Lord! O Lord! You are my last redeemer. *(Puts a record on the gramophone)* Hear my prayer, my kind and loving Lord. *(The record plays a raucous can-can)* Damn! I put the wrong record on!

END OF ACT I

ACT II

SCENE ONE

(Nastya is reading a book)

NASTYA. *(Reading)* "'Milord,' cried the princess, 'I never said I loved you. You are mistaken.' 'Princess,' cried milord, 'take my sabre and run me through.'" Oh, what a desperate character this milord is! How charming. "'You poor, unfortunate man,' cried the princess, 'then you truly do love me?' 'Alas,' cried milord, 'do I love you? I love you as a bird loves freedom.'" Oh what a charming man this milord is! It's simply amazing. "'In that case,' cried the princess, 'I cast off my mask of deception.' And they joined their lips in ecstasy." Lord Almighty, what a life! And that's the kind of life they destroyed. If only our government had known what a princess's life was like, it could never have done what it did. "But love is as a mirage, and into the room marched the duke." Uh-oh. Now there's going to be fireworks. This duke is a terribly typical man. No matter who he meets, he gives them an earful.

SCENE TWO

(Enter Ivan)

NASTYA. "'Scoundrel,' cried the duke. 'You have no right being in this room.'"

IVAN. How can you talk to me like that, Anastasiya Nikolayevna?

NASTYA. "'Scoundrel! Behind my back you deprive me of my honor!'"

IVAN. As God is my witness, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, it's not true. I give you my word, that's just the way it seemed.

NASTYA. Oh! Ivan Ivanovich.

IVAN. Believe me, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, a woman's honor for me is not just an empty word. It's my whole reason for being. However, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, I do sense the moral need to find solace in a woman's soul.

NASTYA. What are you saying, Ivan Ivanovich?

IVAN. Remember, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, I am a bachelor and I have no one to patch my linen. Furthermore, you are a hefty woman and a man could easily lose himself in you.

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, I am a rather young lady and I am forbidden to

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understand whatever it is you're talking about.

IVAN. And please, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, don't give a thought to my moustache. At heart, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, I am truly a child.

NASTYA. No, no! What makes you say so? A moustache is a gift from God. Only you shouldn't wear it inside out, Ivan Ivanovich.

IVAN. What do you mean, inside out?

NASTYA. You let it dangle downwards, Ivan Ivanovich. You should make it stand up in the air. Then it will be a sight for anyone's sore eyes.

IVAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, a man's moustache requires a woman's caresses. Otherwise, it can't possibly grow as it should. But should your hands give it the proper prompting, it will remain in everlasting bliss.

NASTYA. Oh, Ivan Ivanovich. I couldn't.

IVAN. You can, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. Believe me, you can.

NASTYA. Oh, no.

IVAN. Just give it a little try.

NASTYA. But why should I go touching somebody else's moustache?

IVAN. For curiosity's sake if nothing else, Anastasiya Nikolayevna.

NASTYA. Well, if only for curiosity's sake, Ivan Ivanovich. But don't go getting any ideas in your head.

IVAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, I never have any thoughts in my head.

NASTYA. In that case, I'll try. Hmm, No matter what I do it won't stand up. You probably had a moustache like that from birth.

IVAN. Wet your fingers a bit, Anastasiya Nikolayevna.

NASTYA. Oh, with pleasure.

IVAN. Believe me, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, you are penetrating through my moustache to my very heart.

NASTYA. Milord, I never said I loved you. You are forgetting yourself.

IVAN. Pardon me. That was just an impulse of madness. However, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, you should know that when it comes to love, I fear nothing. If you would like to join with me for eternity, I am willing.

NASTYA. Your personality is but little known to me. I can't possibly know whether you may even have children somewhere.

IVAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, children are no shame. They are a misfortune. But if you have reservations about my exterior appearance....

NASTYA. Oh, no. Your exterior appearance is quite proportional.

IVAN. Or, perhaps, concerning the manner in which I dress?

NASTYA. Oh, no. Nothing like that.

IVAN. Because, if you take a close look at my necktie, you will notice that I dress with great comfort.

NASTYA. You have a very handsome necktie. Only why have you tied it up with macaroni?

IVAN. What macaroni?

NASTYA. Right here, Ivan Ivanovich. A string of genuine macaroni.

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IVAN. Oh, that scoundrel.

NASTYA. Cried the duke.

IVAN. What?

NASTYA. Just a reflex. But tell me, who are you talking about, if you'll pardon my expression.

IVAN. Who else? Pavel Sergeyevich, of course.

NASTYA. Pavel Sergeyevich?

IVAN. Incidentally, tell me please, when did your Pavel Sergeyevich find time to join the Party?

NASTYA. He hasn't joined any parties, Ivan Ivanovich.

IVAN. How's that?

NASTYA. Quite simple.

IVAN. He didn't join the Party? Quick! Where did you put that strand of macaroni you took off my tie?

NASTYA. On the floor, Ivan Ivanovich.

IVAN. On the floor? Where is it?

NASTYA. You're wasting your time looking for it, Ivan Ivanovich. Because eating macaroni that you've already stepped on is very dangerous for the stomach.

IVAN. Just give it to me quick, please. I'll be right back. (*Leaves*)

SCENE THREE

NASTYA. Oh, how he expressed his feelings so delicately and then, all of a sudden, macaroni. Ah, here it is, I think. Yes, that's it. Just imagine, such a tiny piece of dough and it's capable of destroying dreams. If he was just making fun of me with everything he said, then he should be rather ashamed. But if he wasn't just making fun of me, then I'm prepared to throw off my mask of deception and tell him, "I'm willing." Joining for eternity with a gentleman like Ivan Ivanovich would be pleasant entertainment for any girl.

SCENE FOUR

(*Enter Ivan*)

IVAN. Well? Did you find it?

NASTYA. Lord Almighty, Ivan Ivanovich, why did you put a pot on your head?

IVAN. For God's sake, don't say that I put it on. Let them think that I never took it off.

NASTYA. What do you mean, you never took it off? Are you telling me that

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you ordinarily go around in a pot, Ivan Ivanovich?

IVAN. I am temporarily compelled to. But where is my macaroni, Anastasiya Nikolayevna?

NASTYA. First of all, Ivan Ivanovich, you ought to wipe the dirt off with a rag.

IVAN. On the contrary, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. The dirtier the better. Let impartial justice see how former landlords bury hard-working citizens in filth by means of milk and macaroni.

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, where are you going, looking like that?

IVAN. To the police, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. To the police. (*Leaves*)

SCENE FIVE

NASTYA. To the police? Ivan Ivanovich! Ivan Ivanovich! Come back! For heaven's sake, come back, I tell you! He's gone. Obviously, once the police get hold of a man in head attire like that, they'll never let him back out again. Oh no! Sounds like someone is trying to sneak in the back door. It's probably the mistress. I'd better hide "The Martyr Queen" under my pillow. Nadezhda Petrovna is opposed to all forms of self-education. (*Leaves*)

SCENE SIX

(*Enter Varvara*)

VARVARA. Come in. Come in.

SCENE SEVEN

(*Enter the Hurdy-Gurdy Man*)

VARVARA. Stand up against this wall and begin, please. Well? What are you waiting for?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. It's all the same to me, of course, but I think I'd better go out on the street and you can listen to me through the window.

VARVARA. What?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I don't like wasting words, miss, but my music is outdoors music.

VARVARA. Why, you're nothing but a cheat. How come you agreed earlier to do what I asked you?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I thought you were inviting me to a birthday party or a drunken orgy of some sort. I don't play in private living quarters for an

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audience of one.

VARVARA. But don't you understand? The point is to drive someone out.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I understand perfectly. Lots of people are being driven out of their minds these days because old heads can't fathom the new life.

VARVARA. We're not driving anyone out of their mind, we're driving a boarder out of our apartment.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Oh, a boarder. Oh, well that's a different story. What are you driving him out for, mademoiselle?

VARVARA. Because he's a hooligan. Can you imagine? He wants to make me a virgin to the end of my days.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Oh, come now, mademoiselle. How could he possibly make a virgin out of you?

VARVARA. You probably have not noticed that I am a bride. That's right, a bride. Well, this morning my brother Pavel Sergeyevich posed an ultimatum concerning this boarder of ours. He said, "If you don't drive him out of our apartment, then you can just stay a virgin."

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Yes, well of course that's a shame. Because virginity is a little bit like a guard dog. He may not partake himself, but he doesn't let anyone else get at the goods either.

VARVARA. Exactly. So mama and I have decided to drive him out.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I see. What kind of music do you adore most?

VARVARA. Hymns.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Mademoiselle, I have a Soviet instrument. It doesn't play church music.

VARVARA. Well then, play what ever you can, only play it loud.

(The Hurdy-Gurdy Man plays, Varvara sings)

VOICE OF NASTYA. I'm coming, Varvara Sergeyevna! Don't panic! I'll be right there!

SCENE EIGHT

(Nastya enters at a run)

NASTYA. Here I am. Holy Mother of God! She's alive! She's alive!

VARVARA. Who's alive?

NASTYA. You, Varvara Sergeyevna. You're alive, thank God. You're alive.

VARVARA. Have you gone insane? Or have you just gone out of your mind?

NASTYA. What do you mean, Varvara Sergeyevna? I was just standing in the kitchen with the neighbor's cook and she says to me, "I think somebody's murdering your Varvara Sergeyevna, because she's screaming in an unearthly voice."

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VARVARA. Who has an unearthly voice? First of all, that's what my own personal voice sounds like and, second of all, you're an idiot.

NASTYA. These are dangerous times, Varvara Sergeyevna. How was I to know?

VARVARA. That's enough talk from you. Start dancing!

NASTYA. What?

VARVARA. Start dancing, I told you.

NASTYA. I don't dance, mademoiselle.

VARVARA. What do you mean, you don't dance? If we hired you to do any dirty work we want, you don't have the full right to refuse our demands. And if I tell you to dance, that means you dance. Play on, play on, dear man. Sing. Sing louder. Nastya, dance. Dance louder. Like they do at royal ceremonies. What am I doing? Wait! Wait a minute! Nastya, come here. Smell me. Have I lost my smell? Well? Speak up. Have I? Do I still smell?

NASTYA. You smell a little bit.

VARVARA. Thank God. Otherwise, all this dancing could make all my aroma from the hairdressers fly right out the window. I'm trying to preserve my aroma for Valerian Olimpovich.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I have a feeling that he's already packing, mademoiselle. Because I've already broken a sweat.

NASTYA. Who is packing?

VARVARA. Ivan Ivanovich.

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich? He's not here.

VARVARA. Where is he?

NASTYA. Who?

VARVARA. Ivan Ivanovich.

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich?

VARVARA. Yes.

NASTYA. In a pot.

VARVARA. Where?

NASTYA. That is, I meant to say that he is probably..., that he has probably gone.

VARVARA. You mean we've been playing for nothing?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. No.

VARVARA. What do you mean, no?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I mean, no. Maybe you were singing for nothing, but you will be kind to pay me what I am owed for my music.

VARVARA. Wait a minute. Who are you?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. What do you mean, who?

VARVARA. I mean, who are you?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Me? I'm a folk artist.

VARVARA. No, I mean what's your class?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Oh, my class? I finished two years at the religious

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seminary.

VARVARA. That's not what I'm talking about. Are you from the working class?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. No. My background is artificial. I'm a self-taught artist.

VARVARA. Oh, what a shame.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. What's it to you?

VARVARA. It's nothing to me. It's my brother I was thinking about. You see, I promised him I'd find some relatives from the working class.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Relatives?

VARVARA. Exactly. You see, some members of the Bolshevik Party are supposed to pay him a visit today, but he doesn't have any relatives from the working class.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Why didn't you do something about that before..., uh..., mademoiselle?

VARVARA. Because before, you didn't need relatives to do your work for you.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. So what are you planning to do, mademoiselle?

VARVARA. I've got to rent some proletarians. Only, where will I ever find them?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Ah, finding rapsallions like that is easy.

VARVARA. Listen. Maybe you could help me.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. What makes you think I can't?

VARVARA. You see, mama baked a sturgeon pie today and then we'll also have a whole lot of French candy. Basically, we're prepared to go to any lengths for the working class.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. That's for the body. What are you prepared to offer for the soul?

VARVARA. What do you mean, for the soul?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Well, for example, will you have spirits?

VARVARA. We will.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. You will?

VARVARA. We will.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I can't for the life of me figure out how it slipped my mind.

VARVARA. What's that?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. You see, it just so happens that I'm from the working class myself.

VARVARA. Oh, what a surprise!

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Tell me, mademoiselle, what quantity of relatives will you be needing?

VARVARA. I would say three people will do. One relative for every communist.

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HURDY-GURDY MAN. Well, I would say there ought to be one bottle for every relative.

VARVARA. In that case, we'll be expecting you.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. It's a deal.

VARVARA. Nastya. See this gentleman out the servants entrance and pick up three bottles of port at the grocery store. Got that?

NASTYA. Got it, mademoiselle.

VARVARA. Step to it!

(Nastya and the Hurdy-Gurdy Man leave)

SCENE NINE

VARVARA. Cares, cares. Nothing but cares and no fun. Once a month you get to go to the hairdresser and that's the only fun you have. Mama doesn't let me go to church anymore. She says I might get killed. The bathhouse is filled with all kinds of riffraff these days. It's no fun going there. Basically, in the arisen situation there's simply nowhere for a cultured girl to go. But all I want to know is whether Valerian Olimpovich will like me or not. I think he'll like me. I have a very beautiful soul and eyelashes. Plus, my smile is very becoming to my face. Only, it's too bad that it doesn't fit on this mirror.

SCENE TEN

(Enter Pavel)

PAVEL. Varya, what are you making ugly faces for?

VARVARA. I think they quite suit me.

PAVEL. With a mug like yours, any ugly face would suit you. Only, you'd better think about your brother too, Varvara. For instance, does a sister like you suit him?

VARVARA. Pavlusha, that's not my mug, it's my smile.

PAVEL. Your smile, huh? Being an honest person, I declare here and now that if you greet my guests this evening with smiles like that I'll renounce you.

VARVARA. You can't renounce me.

PAVEL. And I'm telling you that I'll not only renounce you, I'll disgrace you for life.

VARVARA. How could you possibly disgrace me?

PAVEL. Simple. I'll say you're my aunt, not my sister.

VARVARA. Pavel, how can you call me such names when I went out and

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found you a relative? What impudence.

PAVEL. You did? Is he a worker?

VARVARA. He is.

PAVEL. What kind of work does he do?

VARVARA. He works with his hands. So, are your communists coming?

PAVEL. They are. Utkin himself promised to bring them.

VARVARA. Then you might say you're almost a full-fledged party member now.

PAVEL. From head to toe. Look, I even bought a briefcase. Only I don't have a party i.d. card yet.

VARVARA. So what, Pavel? If you have a briefcase, any door will open for you even without a party i.d. card.

PAVEL. Varya! A new life is beginning! Oh, by the way, do you happen to know what the R.C.P. is, Varya?¹

VARVARA. The R.C.P.? No. Why do you need to know?

PAVEL. Because Utkin told me, "These days, every idiot knows what the R.C.P. is."

VARVARA. In that case, how come you don't know, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. Well, I probably used to know. But a party man has so much to think about, sometime he goes and forgets.

VARVARA. Pavel, look. A trunk.

PAVEL. A trunk? Where?

VARVARA. Right here.

PAVEL. I'll be darned. A trunk.

VARVARA. Strange.

PAVEL. I'd say it's darned strange.

VARVARA. What could be in it?

PAVEL. Take a look.

VARVARA. There's a lock on it, Pavel.

PAVEL. I'll be darned. A lock.

VARVARA. Amazing.

PAVEL. I'd say it's darned amazing. How come mama is always complaining that we have nothing left in our trunks? If you ask her, "Mama, where are papa's trousers," she always says, "We ate them up, Pavlusha, we ate them up. Back in nineteen-eighteen we traded all of our belongings for flour and we ate it all up." And then, Varya, if you ask her for money, she always says, "How could we possibly have any money, Pavlusha? They took it all away from us in nineteen-eighteen." So then you ask her, "What do we live on, mama?" And she says, "Pavlusha, we're eating up the last of your father's trousers." Can you imagine what papa's trousers must have been like if they're enough to sustain an entire family?

¹ The Russian Communist Party.

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VARVARA. Well, it looks like mama still has something left over beside papa's trousers.

PAVEL. It looks like it, Varya. Otherwise, why would she lock up her trunks?

VARVARA. Pavel, it's just a tiny little lock.

PAVEL. Yeah. It's not much of a lock.

VARVARA. I'll bet you could open a lock like that with a fork.

PAVEL. A fork? I don't think a fork would do it. But a nail would definitely do the trick.

VARVARA. Wait a second. (*Gives him a nail*)

PAVEL. What if we get caught?

VARVARA. Who'd catch us, Pavel? By all appearances, we're honest people. Nobody would ever suspect us.

PAVEL. What if mama found out?

VARVARA. Mama would instantly suspect Nastya, because all cooks are crooks. And our cook is probably a crook too.

PAVEL. Yeah. I'll bet she's definitely a crook, Varvara. She's got something awful strange about her eyes.

VARVARA. She's a crook, Pavel. A crook.

PAVEL. It's simply unbelievable how many dishonest people there are these days.

VARVARA. Pavel, do you need some light? (*Takes the lamp off the table*)

PAVEL. That's it. Shine it right here. Put it on the floor.

(*Varvara puts the lamp on the floor*)

SCENE ELEVEN

(*Enter Nadezhda*)

NADEZHDA. There seems to be some sort of an eclipse in here. Mother Redeemer, what if someone is trying to break into the imperial dress?

VARVARA. Well, is it giving yet?

PAVEL. It's giving. Any minute now.

NADEZHDA. Thieves! Somebody is breaking in. Where did I put that pistol? Oh, Lord. Oh, Lord Almighty, here it is. The desperadoes will see me. As God is my witness, they'll see me. Oh, no! They're getting up. Help! I'll shoot!

VARVARA. Help! Thieves!

PAVEL. Get down! They'll shoot!

NADEZHDA. Help!

PAVEL and VARVARA. Help!

NADEZHDA. They're probably bolsheviks or bandits of some sort.

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PAVEL. Comrade!

NADEZHDA. That settles that. Bolsheviks. I only pray they don't shoot.

Please, don't let them shoot! (*The pistol fires*)

PAVEL. Varya, touch me. Am I alive?

VARVARA. I think so.

NADEZHDA. Lordy heavens! I've given myself a concussion.

PAVEL. What about you?

VARVARA. I think I'm only barely alive.

NADEZHDA. They're whispering. I can hear them whispering. They've probably come to arrest me, the desperadoes. Oh, they're going to arrest me.

PAVEL. Comrade! Please note that we are children. Word of honor, we're only children. The hope of the future, as they say.

NADEZHDA. It was Tamara Leopoldovna who dumped that dress on me.

Word of honor, it was Tamara Leopoldovna.

PAVEL. Comrade, what good will it do you to shoot us? When our mama comes in a minute, shoot her.

NADEZHDA. Tell me straight out, are you bolsheviks or bandits?

PAVEL. We're unaligned, comrade. Third-rate unaligned.

NADEZHDA. Glory be to God! They're only bandits. Help! Thieves!

VARVARA. Help! Murder!

PAVEL. Comrade! Mama!

NADEZHDA. Help! I'll shoot!

PAVEL. Mama, what are you doing? It's me, Pavel!

NADEZHDA. You? Is it really you?

PAVEL. It's me, mama. It's me.

VARVARA. It's him, mama. It's him.

PAVEL. What's wrong with you, mama? Can't you see for yourself?

NADEZHDA. How do you think I can see, Pavel, when I've got both eyes shut tight?

PAVEL. Mama! Open your eyes this instant. Otherwise there may be a catastrophe.

NADEZHDA. How can I open them, Pavlusha, when this pistol is going to go off at any second?

PAVEL. She's going to shoot! Varya, hit the deck! Mama! You're aiming at me again! Turn it around, mama. Turn it on yourself. The barrel, the barrel. Turn the barrel on yourself. Aim at yourself. Aim at yourself, I tell you. For God's sake, otherwise you're going to shoot us!

NADEZHDA. It's going to explode, Pavlusha. As God is my witness, it's going to explode!

PAVEL. Duck, Varya!

VARVARA. Mama, put it down somewhere!

NADEZHDA. Varya, how can I put it down when the slightest movement

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will make it fire?

PAVEL. Mama, what got into your head to turn our apartment into a civil war zone?

VARVARA. Mama, I have a feeling it's beginning to shoot.

NADEZHDA. Children mine! Pay my respects to Mister Smetanich. I'm dying. It's going to explode. (*Drops the pistol on the chair*)

PAVEL. Did it miss me?

VARVARA. Where did it fall, mama?

NADEZHDA. On the chair.

PAVEL. Now explain, please, mama. Where did you get a firearm?

NADEZHDA. Tamara Leopoldovna gave it to me, Pavlusha.

PAVEL. What for?

NADEZHDA. For the dress's self-defense, Pavlusha.

VARVARA. The dress?

PAVEL. What dress?

NADEZHDA. The dress that used to contain our whole empire, Pavlusha.

VARVARA. And what contains it now, mama?

NADEZHDA. The trunk, Varya.

PAVEL. How does it fit in there, mama?

NADEZHDA. Because, Pavlusha, they shook the whole empire right out of it.

VARVARA. Whose dress is it, mama?

NADEZHDA. First of all, swear to God that you won't tell a soul, because I already swore to God that I wouldn't tell.

VARVARA. I swear to God, I won't tell.

PAVEL. I can't swear to God. These days we're ruled by a dictatorship of the proletariat.

VARVARA. Go ahead and swear, Pavel. The proletariat will never hear.

PAVEL. I swear to God, I won't tell.

NADEZHDA. This dress, my children, belonged to our sovereign, the Empress Alexandra Fyodorovna.

VARVARA. Oh, how interesting.

PAVEL. Pardon my hinting, mama, but that's a lie.

NADEZHDA. I'm not lying any more than I do at confession. Look for yourself, if you want.

PAVEL. Mama! It's almost brand new.

VARVARA. Only the armpits are a bit worn.

NADEZHDA. That's from regal sweat, Varya.

VARVARA. Because she worked so hard?

PAVEL. What are you talking about, Varya? Do you think the empress ever did any work?

VARVARA. Then what did she sweat for, mama?

NADEZHDA. From praying.

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VARVARA. Oh, that must have been an awfully bold seamstress not to fear sewing dresses for the sovereign.

PAVEL. You idiot, Varya. Seamstresses don't sew for sovereigns.

VARVARA. Then who does?

PAVEL. A general's wife of some kind. Or maybe even a countess.

VARVARA. Mama, I wish we could see what it looks like when there's a woman in it.

PAVEL. There aren't any women like that in Russia anymore.

VARVARA. What if I tried it on?

NADEZHDA. You?

PAVEL. You don't have enough of a build to wear a dress like that.

VARVARA. I always was offended at you for making me so short, mama.

SCENE TWELVE

(Enter Nastya)

NASTYA. Here are your three bottles, mademoiselle.

PAVEL. Nastya, snap to attention and don't move!

NASTYA. What?

PAVEL. Snap to attention, I say. Look, mama, Nastya is just the right size.

NADEZHDA. But what's the point, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. For the illusion of a regal life, mama.

NADEZHDA. Well, of course, I'd be curious to see myself. Only, what if someone finds out?

VARVARA. We'll just put it on for a second and then stash it away again.

NADEZHDA. I don't think we should, Varya. She's a dirty woman. After all, she works in the kitchen.

VARVARA. Yes, she is dirty. Nastya, go get my perfume soap in the washroom and I'll scrub your ears myself.

NASTYA. What for, mademoiselle?

VARVARA. For..., how did you put it, Pavlusha?

PAVEL. For the illusion of a regal life.

VARVARA. That's it exactly. Let's go.

(Varvara, carrying the dress, leaves with Nastya)

SCENE THIRTEEN

NADEZHDA. You know what, Pavlusha? Tamara Leopoldovna promised to petition for a pension for me.

PAVEL. A pension for what?

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NADEZHDA. For saving Russia.

PAVEL. What do you mean, for saving Russia? First of all, the communists will never let you to save Russia.

NADEZHDA. Pavlusha, who cares what they want when any day now the French are going to sneak a tsar into Russia?

PAVEL. What tsar? Do you realize what you are saying, mama? If somebody really does sneak a tsar into Russia, the first thing they'll do is hang me, no questions asked. After that, you just try to prove that I'm only a dowry and not a communist.

NADEZHDA. That's where the dress will save you.

PAVEL. Mama, I oppose this dress with every fibre in my body.

NADEZHDA. But, Pavel.

PAVEL. If we don't liquidate it this instant, then somebody else is going to liquidate me.

NADEZHDA. But what about the pension, Pavel?

PAVEL. Mama, I can't help but ask, what good is your pension if I'm a dead man?

NADEZHDA. But maybe they'll erect a stone monument to you for your heroism.

PAVEL. You think they would?

NADEZHDA. For heroism like that, there can't be any doubt. For the edification of future generations. You'd be like the first book printer or something.

PAVEL. You don't think people would confuse me with him?

NADEZHDA. Pavel, nobody could ever confuse you with anybody. You have a very imposing figure.

PAVEL. Then maybe I'd better not join the Party, mama.

NADEZHDA. Why not? Then what would we use to marry off Varya?

PAVEL. But, mama, you're forgetting that under the old regime I could be doomed to a martyr's death for sympathizing with the new order.

NADEZHDA. How could you possibly be doomed if you are the possessor of the dress?

PAVEL. With logic like that, under the new regime this dress and I could be doomed to a martyr's death for sympathizing with the old order.

NADEZHDA. How could you possibly be doomed if you're a party member?

PAVEL. Mama, what you are saying is that I am immortal no matter what the regime. Just think, mama. What a monument I'll be! For example, say some foreigners come to Moscow. They'll ask, "Where are the finest sights in your city?" "Right here," people will say. Then they'll ask, "Who is this, Peter the Great?" And they'll say, "No. Raise your sights a little higher. This is Pavel Sergeyevich Gulyachkin."

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SCENE FOURTEEN

(Enter Varvara)

VARVARA. The dress fits Nastya perfectly.

NADEZHDA. You don't say. Where is she?

VARVARA. She's coming.

PAVEL. What if a real empress was coming out right now? How would we greet her? "Hello"? or "My compliments"?

NADEZHDA. One doesn't say "hello" to an empress. One says "Hurrah!"

VARVARA. And what do we call her? "Queen Mother"?

NADEZHDA. Only Mothers of God are called "Mother." Empresses are called "Your Majesties."

VARVARA. Are you coming?

VOICE OF NASTYA. I'll be right there.

PAVEL. It's only our cook and my knees are already shaking.

SCENE FIFTEEN

(Enter Nastya in the empress's dress and carrying a fan)

THE THREE GULYACHKINS. Hurrah, Your Majesty!

NADEZHDA. She looks so real. It's amazing how real she looks.

VARVARA. Mama, I'm getting stomach cramps from so much luxury.

PAVEL. Nastya, sweetheart, walk around the room. We'd like to get a glimpse of your other side.

VARVARA. Oh, Nastya. You simply walk without the slightest bit of taste. When I saw an English queen at the Maly Theater once, she moved across the floor exclusively like this. *(Demonstrates)*

PAVEL. Go on, Nastya, try it.

NADEZHDA. Do something with her train. Her train is dragging on the ground.

PAVEL. Allow me, mama. *(Carries her train)*

NADEZHDA. She looks so real. It's amazing how real she looks.

PAVEL. If only I'd had something like this to grab onto in peacetime, I would have gone a long way, mama.

VARVARA. Pavel, seat her on the throne.

PAVEL. Please be seated, Your Majesty. *(Seats Nastya on the chair)*

NADEZHDA. She looks so real. It's amazing how real she looks.

VARVARA. If we seated a real empress on the throne, mama, they'd be sure to give us a grocery store.

PAVEL. They'd make me prime minister.

NADEZHDA. Maybe a policeman at least, Pavel. Because doing business

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with your own policeman on your side is a good thing. It's legal and profitable.

NASTYA. What am I sitting on?

PAVEL. A throne, Your Majesty.

NADEZHDA. Help! Every man for himself!

PAVEL and VARVARA. What happened?

NASTYA. What's wrong, madame?

NADEZHDA. Nastya, don't move. In the name of Christ, I invoke you, don't move. Because you are sitting on a loaded pistol.

NASTYA. A pistol? Citizens! Murder!

NADEZHDA. Nastya, don't squirm!

PAVEL. Nastya, sit there like a stunned bird or you'll kill us and yourself too.

VARVARA. Nastya, if you so much as budge, it'll shoot.

NASTYA. Heavens, I'm done for.

NADEZHDA. Don't move, I tell you!

PAVEL. Nastya, can you feel with the spot that you're sitting on which direction it's pointed in?

NASTYA. Pavel Sergeyevich, every spot on me has gone numb from terror.

PAVEL. Mama, I can't exist under the conditions of a fire attack. We're going to have to move to another apartment.

NASTYA. But Pavel Sergeyevich, you can't leave me all alone riding side saddle on a pistol.

NADEZHDA. Nastya, quit shivering! Nastya, don't shiver, because there are still seven bullets in there.

VARVARA. If only we knew which direction it might fire.

NASTYA. Oh my God! I think I just felt the trigger with something.

PAVEL. Everybody, under the chair! Dive under the chair! When it shoots, it won't shoot down, it'll shoot straight out.

(They crawl under the chair)

NASTYA. If you bump the chair with anything, I'll explode.

PAVEL. Mama, you're to blame for all of this.

NADEZHDA. No, it's Varya's fault, Pavlusha. "Let's seat her on the throne," she says. Well, she's sitting pretty now.

PAVEL. At the present moment, mama, she's sitting on all our heads.

NASTYA. Ah!

THE THREE GULYACHKINS. Oh!

PAVEL. Mama, have them bury me ceremoniously with music. After all, I'm dying under the yoke of the monarchy.

(The doorbell rings)

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NADEZHDA. Heavens, someone is at the door.

VARVARA. It's probably Mister Smetanich.

NADEZHDA. Holy Saints, what are we going to do?

PAVEL. Nastya, sweetheart, while we are still sitting under you under the chair, try to get up as carefully as you can. If the pistol fires, maybe it'll miss.

NASTYA. What if it fires?! Get another pistol and shoot me if you want, but I'm not budging off of this one.

NADEZHDA. Oh, my Lord. The doorbell again.

VARVARA. Mama, what are we going to do?

NADEZHDA. Cover her up with something, quick. Throw something over her and I'll go open the door. (*Leaves*)

SCENE SIXTEEN

PAVEL. Varya, drag a curtain over here. Or make it a rug.

NASTYA. Pavel Sergeyevich, I think I'm beginning to detect the smell of gun powder wafting up from under me.

PAVEL. Cover her up good! Tighter, wrap it tighter!

NASTYA. Oh! I'm suffocating.

VARVARA. Well, suffocate if you have to. Only don't move!

SCENE SEVENTEEN

(*Enter Nadezhda, Olimp and his son Valerian*)

NADEZHDA. This way, Olimp Valerianovich. Right this way.

OLIMP. What have we here, Nadezhda Petrovna? Your dining room?

NADEZHDA. Yes, yes, Olimp Valerianovich. This is our dining room. And this is my daughter Varya.

OLIMP. I'm charmed to meet you, mademoiselle.

VARVARA. Oh, it's nothing. Nonsense, really.

OLIMP. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. Say hello to Varvara Sergeyevna.

VALERIAN. I'm charmed.

VARVARA. Oh, you don't mean it.

NASTYA. A-choo!

ALL. Ah!

OLIMP. What seems to be the problem, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. I'm dying.

OLIMP. What do you mean, you're dying? You mean, really?

NADEZHDA. Yes..., that is..., no. Pardon me, I... I think I'm all better now.

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VALERIAN. I have the distinct impression that someone sneezed in here.

NADEZHDA. Oh, how could you, Valerian Olimpovich? My children are well-bred. They would never allow themselves such a thing.

VALERIAN. A-choo.

NADEZHDA. That is, I mean to say that one can pass the time quite pleasantly even when sneezing.

VARVARA. Mama, look. He's standing right next to the chair.

NADEZHDA. Varya, shut up while nobody's noticed anything. Olimp Valerianovich, I would like you to meet my communist son, Pavlusha.

OLIMP. Aha. So you have already joined the Party, have you, young man? When was it that you joined?

PAVEL. Well, you see, it was, uh, nineteen, I think, o-five... that I started thinking, that is to say, I had the impulse, because as our beloved teacher Engels said...

OLIMP. What did he say?

PAVEL. It, uh... he, uh.... Well, in a word, he said a great deal and one would never be able to remember it all.

OLIMP. Well, tell me, young man, how was it that you joined the Party? Out of convictions, or was it, uh...

PAVEL. That, I don't know. How did it happen, mama?

NADEZHDA. Olimp Valerianovich, this boy of mine is truly a wonder, he's capable of doing anything in any way you can possibly imagine.

OLIMP. I see. But tell me, young man, do you have a protege?

PAVEL. A protege?

OLIMP. A protege. Well, how does one put it? An obliging boss?

PAVEL. Obliging?

OLIMP. Well, yes. That is to say, a boss who, shall we say, has dinner at your house and will definitely find the proper occasion to return the favor.

NADEZHDA. Pavel knows Utkin himself, Olimp Valerianovich.

OLIMP. Who is Utkin?

NADEZHDA. A very famous person, Olimp Valerianovich. Just imagine, he has three communist relatives.

PAVEL. They promised to come see us today, Olimp Valerianovich.

OLIMP. They're coming here? Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. Pin your air force pin to your jacket this minute. And do what you can not to express your convictions.

VALERIAN. No problem with the pin, but as for the convictions, I don't have any. I'm an anarchist.

OLIMP. Children in our circle, Nadezhda Petrovna, always say what they shouldn't, because they repeat what they hear their parents say. However, do tell me, Nadezhda Petrovna, why is it that you keep a rug here instead of spreading it on the floor?

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NADEZHDA. Don't touch it, Olimp Valerianovich. I beg you not to touch it.

OLIMP. Why is that, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. It..., it..., it... is very dirty and then..., won't you please follow me into the other room, Olimp Valerianovich?

OLIMP. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. Engage Varvara Sergeyevna in conversation. I'll be right back. Shall we go, Nadezhda Petrovna? After you, Pavel Sergeyevich.

PAVEL. Oh, no. I wouldn't think of it. You go first and I'll just tag along somehow.

(Nadezhda, Olimp and Pavel leave)

SCENE EIGHTEEN

VALERIAN. Tell me, mademoiselle, do you play the piano?

VARVARA. I never seem to have had the occasion to.

VALERIAN. Perhaps, mademoiselle, you have taken note of what the Soviet government has done to the arts?

VARVARA. Oh, you'll have to forgive me. I haven't noticed.

VALERIAN. Just imagine, it has taken free professionals and turned them into cabbies.

VARVARA. Oh, what a shame.

VALERIAN. I don't say that in an imagistic sense, but in the sense of the rent they now charge for apartments.

NASTYA. It's going to shoot.

VALERIAN. What happened? Who said it's going to shoot?

VARVARA. That, uh..., was me.

VALERIAN. You? Who's shooting who?

VARVARA. I, uh..., you see, I..., I have this shooting pain in my back.

VALERIAN. In your back? Well, mademoiselle, how do you find Einstein's theory of relativity?

VARVARA. Oh, it played at our local theater. Only Pavel told me it was just a travelogue without much of a story.

VALERIAN. Do you often go to the movies?

VARVARA. On the contrary. I find it awkward to go often.

VALERIAN. Awkward? Why is that?

VARVARA. It's dark and there are a lot of strange men there.

VALERIAN. Wait a minute. Who is that sniffing?

VARVARA. Valerian Olimpovich.

VALERIAN. What?

VARVARA. I..., I..., I meant to say...

VALERIAN. What did you mean to say?

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VARVARA. That is, I..., I..., I meant to ask...

VALERIAN. What did you mean to ask?

VARVARA. Lord, what am I going to ask him? Well, then..., you..., you... don't seem to wear a pince-nez.

VALERIAN. No. I have very healthy eyes.

VARVARA. Oh, what a shame. A pince-nez is very becoming to a man.

VALERIAN. Listen. Somebody is sniffing again.

VARVARA. That was..., that was me.

VALERIAN. You?

VARVARA. Shall we go into the living room, Valerian Olimpovich?

VALERIAN. Maybe we should remain here in the dining room, Varvara Sergeyevna.

VARVARA. For goodness sake, let's go into the living room, Valerian Olimpovich.

VALERIAN. In that case, allow me to offer you my hand, mademoiselle.

VARVARA. My, but you do work quickly, Valerian Olimpovich. I'm ashamed to think of it. However, I accept.

VALERIAN. You have misunderstood me, Varvara Sergeyevna.

VARVARA. Nothing of the sort, Valerian Olimpovich. I understand you perfectly well. But perhaps you ought to negotiate with my mother first.

VALERIAN. That's what's called getting stuck like a pig. (*Leaves*)

SCENE NINETEEN

VARVARA. Oh, what an impossibly passionate man he is!

SCENE TWENTY

(*Enter Nadezhda and Pavel*)

NADEZHDA. Varvara, why did you let Valerian Olimpovich out of your clutches?

VARVARA. But mama, he just made me a proposal.

NADEZHDA. Varya, why are you such a shameless liar?

VARVARA. Honest, mama, I'm not a liar. "Allow me," he said, "to offer you my hand, mademoiselle."

NADEZHDA. That's what he said?

VARVARA. That's what he said.

PAVEL. What is Nastya up to?

VARVARA. She's sniffing and sneezing.

PAVEL. Nastya, what are you sneezing for?

NASTYA. How do you expect me not to sneeze when you buried me in a

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dusty rug?
NADEZHDA. Bear with us a little longer. They'll be gone soon.
VARVARA. Only don't move! Don't move!

SCENE TWENTY-ONE

(Enter the Janitor)

JANITOR. Hello, comrades.
THE THREE GULYACHKINS. Hello, comrade.
JANITOR. So. Well, uh, Pavel Sergeyevich, they want you to put in an appearance at the house committee meeting.
PAVEL. The meeting?
NADEZHDA. What is the meeting about?
JANITOR. It's uh, well, it's about our trash, comrade. See, they uh, want to know when it should be hauled away. This week or next?
PAVEL. Mama, hand me my briefcase. I can't shirk my social duties. I'll go.
VARVARA. Trash. There's a fine social duty for you.
PAVEL. Varya, we just vote about it. It's others who will have to haul it away.

(Leaves with the Janitor)

NADEZHDA. Lock the door after them, Varya!

(Nadezhda and Varvara leave)

SCENE TWENTY-TWO

(Enter Olimp and Valerian)

VALERIAN. So, what you're saying, papa, is that you insist I marry this little peasant?
OLIMP. First of all, she is not a little peasant and second of all, circumstances are making the demand, not I.
VALERIAN. What do you mean she's not a peasant? She uses vegetable oil for perfume.
OLIMP. Nonsense. She'll air out in a day or two.
VALERIAN. Perhaps. But do you consider it decent that she has shooting back pains?
OLIMP. Well, if she were noisy about it, I could understand your reservations. But you won't have to worry about that.

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VALERIAN. But she's not from our circle. She's no match for me.

OLIMP. You forget. Her brother is a perfect match for you. He's in the Party.

VALERIAN. Maybe, but his party is no match for us, either.

OLIMP. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. It's time for you to get acquainted with life.

VALERIAN. Papa, you say that as if we were a family without means.

OLIMP. That's the point. In the old days, we were a family of means and everybody feared us. These days we are still a family of means, which is why we are afraid of everybody. We've got to put an end to that, and I have found just the means.

VALERIAN. What's that, papa?

OLIMP. We shall obtain our very own communist.

VALERIAN. How do you do that, papa?

OLIMP. It depends on you, Valerian.

VALERIAN. On me?

OLIMP. Yes, Valerian. Didn't you know that Nadezhda Petrovna is offering Pavel Sergeyevich as a dowry for her daughter?

VALERIAN. What good could someone like him be of?

OLIMP. Oh, come now. A person like Pavel Sergeyevich isn't a person at all. He's a whole insurance policy. If I need someone to vouch for me, he'll vouch for me. If I need someone to intercede for me, he'll intercede for me. If I need someone to recommend me, he'll recommend me. If I need someone to shine my shoes, he'll shine my shoes.

SCENE TWENTY-THREE

(Enter Nadezhda and Varvara)

NADEZHDA. Have a seat at the table, Olimp Valerianovich. Please have a seat.

VARVARA. The doorbell.

NADEZHDA. That's probably the communists.

ALL. The communists?

NADEZHDA. Varya, get the sturgeon pie off the table and I'll go peek through the peep-hole. *(Leaves)*

SCENE TWENTY-FOUR

OLIMP. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. Look at me. I don't look too decent, do I?

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VALERIAN. No, papa. You look just like you always do.

OLIMP. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. Straighten up the pin on your jacket and sing something in a revolutionary spirit.

VALERIAN. What do you want me to sing?

OLIMP. A song. Any song. For instance, "You Fell a Martyred Victim."

SCENE TWENTY-FIVE

(Enter Nadezhda)

NADEZHDA. That's who it is, the communists. Varya, quick, turn over "Evening in Copenhagen" and I'll turn over "I Believe in Thee, O Lord."

VARVARA. Mama, all of my insides are turning over upside down from terror.

NADEZHDA. I don't give a damn about your insides. These days our whole life is turning upside down. Saints alive! They're ringing again. Quick, Varya, get the bottles out of here and I'll go open the door. What will be will be.

OLIMP. Wait, Nadezhda Petrovna. That is no work for a woman. You step into the next room and Valerian and I will receive them together.

NADEZHDA. The Lord be with you, Olimp Valerianovich. If you need me, call me. God be willing, Pavlusha will be here soon.

(Nadezhda and Varvara leave)

SCENE TWENTY-SIX

OLIMP. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. Wait for me here. *(Leaves)*

(Valerian sings)

SCENE TWENTY-SEVEN

(Enter Olimp, the Hurdy-Gurdy Man, the Drummer and the Woman with a Parrot and Tambourine)

OLIMP. Comrades, be so kind. Come in, come in, please. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

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OLIMP. Why aren't you singing?

VALERIAN. My song is already sung.

DRUMMER. Are these the communists we're playing relatives for?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Probably. Look, that one has a pin.

OLIMP. Sit down, comrades. Please do sit down. Pavel Sergeyevich will be here any minute.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Pavel Sergeyevich? He's Pavlusha to me, my good man. Simply Pavlusha.

OLIMP. Then you have known him for a long time, have you, comrade?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. How could I possibly not know him, my good man, when I am his own dear uncle?

VALERIAN. You are his uncle?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. From the very moment of his birth. You know, I used to finish my shift at the factory and make a beeline to go see him. He'd always be sitting there on his mother's knee and sucking at his mother's breast. So I'd make horns behind my head with my fingers, like this, and I'd say, "Pavlusha! Do you love the working class?" He'd quit sucking instantly and say, "I do, uncle! Oh, how I love it!" And then he'd start shivering all over.

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. That boy was so politically conscious from his very childhood, there's no way you could even describe it.

OLIMP. You know him from childhood, too?

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. My dear, what do you expect when I am his favorite aunt?

VALERIAN. My bride's relatives are all idiots.

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. Whenever we'd go walking past a factory, he always tried breaking in through the walls with his little hands.

OLIMP. Pardon me, comrades, but I've got to leave you for a moment. Valerian!

VALERIAN. Yes, papa.

OLIMP. I can't believe that Nadezhda Petrovna didn't tell us that her relatives are these communists. We've got to go find her.

(Olimp and Valerian leave)

SCENE TWENTY-EIGHT

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. I think we poured it on good and thick.

DRUMMER. I'll say. And now it wouldn't be a bad idea to pour a little down the hatch.

THE WARRANT — ACT II

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Here's the girl.

SCENE TWENTY-NINE

(Enter Varvara)

VARVARA. You're here already?

DRUMMER. Yes, ma'am. We're here, all right.

VARVARA. Where are the communists?

DRUMMER. We already gave them a working over, miss. So now we can move on to the sturgeon pie.

VARVARA. Just a minute. Mama will be right here. *(Leaves)*

SCENE THIRTY

(Enter Nadezhda)

NADEZHDA. Hello, comrades.

ALL. Hello, madame.

NADEZHDA. Did you comrades have a nice chat with Valerian Olimpovich?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. I'd say we had a first-class chat. And now it would be a good idea to wet the whistle.

NADEZHDA. I'll bring you some water right away, comrades.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Water? What water? Are you trying to make fun of us, madame?

NADEZHDA. What makes you think I would dare make fun of you, comrades?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Listen, madame, produce what we agreed on. First of all, sturgeon pie, and then a bottle for each of us.

NADEZHDA. What are you talking about, comrades? We never have sturgeon pie and, as for wine, I've never even set eyes on it. I've heard about it, but I've never had occasion to cross its path.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. You've never crossed its path?

NASTYA. Ow! You stepped on my corn.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. What was that?

NASTYA. Don't touch me or I'll shoot.

ALL. Help! Murder!

(The doorbell rings)

NADEZHDA. Oh, my God. We're done for now.

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SCENE THIRTY-ONE

(Enter Varvara)

VARVARA. Mama, it's Tamara Leopoldovna.

NADEZHDA. Tamara Leopoldovna? Help, I'm dying.

VARVARA. Gentlemen, go into the other room. Go into the other room.

(The Hurdy-Gurdy Man, the Drummer and the Woman with a Parrot and Tambourine leave)

SCENE THIRTY-TWO

NADEZHDA. Nastya! Get up off that chair this instant!

NASTYA. Kill me if you want. But I'm not budging.

VARVARA. Nastya, even if it fires, it won't hurt you where it's aimed.

NASTYA. I can't, Varvara Sergeyevna, as God is my witness, I can't.

NADEZHDA. Varya! Bring two buckets of water!

(Varvara runs out)

SCENE THIRTY-THREE

NASTYA. What's the water for, madame?

NADEZHDA. We'll soak the gun powder under you. They say that wet guns don't shoot. Oh my God! The doorbell again.

SCENE THIRTY-FOUR

(Enter Varvara with buckets)

NADEZHDA. Bring 'em over here! Quick! Quick! Right here. Now, pour them under Nastya.

NASTYA. Madame! I'm drowning!

VARVARA. Nastya, breathe with your nose and you won't drown.

NASTYA. Help! I'm drowning! I'm drowning!

NADEZHDA. It's probably damp by now. Nastya, get up! Grab her by the arms! Grab her by the arms! There. Now, crawl in the trunk!

NASTYA. Why the trunk?

NADEZHDA. Crawl in the trunk, when you're told to crawl in the trunk!

NASTYA. But madame, I'm all wet.

NADEZHDA. You can dry out in there.

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(They put her in the trunk)

Bend your head. Come on, bend it. Varvara, close the trunk and I'll go open the door for Tamara Leopoldovna. *(Leaves)*

(Varvara closes the trunk and leaves)

SCENE THIRTY-FIVE

(Enter Nadezhda and Tamara)

TAMARA. I have been so worried, so worried! Tell me, nothing has happened to it, has it?

NADEZHDA. Rest assured, Tamara Leopoldovna. It's all in one piece.

TAMARA. Oh, show me, Nadezhda Petrovna!

NADEZHDA. Do you mean you don't trust me, Tamara Leopoldovna?

TAMARA. Oh, I'm a bundle of nerves, Nadezhda Petrovna!

NADEZHDA. There are too many strangers around, Tamara Leopoldovna. But look, a tip of it is sticking out here. See?

TAMARA. Oh, what happiness! I have been so worried, so worried!

SCENE THIRTY-SIX

(Enter Ivan)

IVAN. Police! Police! Police!

NADEZHDA. Ivan Ivanovich, what gives you the right to express yourself like that in a dining room? People eat here, they don't express themselves.

IVAN. You're fancy intonations aren't going to help you now. The police will be here any minute.

TAMARA. Help! The police!

SCENE THIRTY-SEVEN

(Enter the Drummer, the Hurdy-Gurdy Man, the Woman with a Parrot and Tambourine, Valerian, Olimp and Varvara)

DRUMMER. Who said, "police"?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. The police?

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. What police?

VALERIAN. What happened?

OLIMP. What is going on?

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NADEZHDA. Ivan Ivanovich, I'll get help from a friendlier precinct.
IVAN. There isn't a soul in the whole republic who can help you now.
VALERIAN. Who is this?
TAMARA. He's probably a commissar. Look at his hat.
VARVARA. Maestro, play! That's the neighbor we're driving out.
HURDY-GURDY MAN. Hit it, men!

(Music plays. Everyone except Tamara and Valerian leaves, shouting: "Police! Police! Police! Help! Help! Help! Play! Play! Play!")

SCENE THIRTY-EIGHT

TAMARA. Young man, do you believe in God?
VALERIAN. Approximately.
TAMARA. Save a helpless woman! Carry away this trunk!
VALERIAN. This trunk? What's in it?
TAMARA. Young man, I'll tell you a state secret. This trunk contains everything that is left of Russia in Russia.
VALERIAN. In that case, it can't be very heavy.
TAMARA. I implore you. Save it or all is lost.
VALERIAN. All right. I'll try.
TAMARA. We only have to make it as far as my cab.

(Tamara and Valerian carry out the trunk)

SCENE THIRTY-NINE

(Varvara, Nadezhda, Olimp, Ivan, the Hurdy-Gurdy Man, the Drummer and the Woman with a Parrot and Tambourine all return. They are all dancing to music)

VARVARA. Play! Play harder! Dance, gentlemen, dance! We're driving him out.
IVAN. So you're frightened, are you, Nadezhda Petrovna? Do you think there are no laws in the Soviet Republic? There are, Nadezhda Petrovna, there are. There isn't a country on earth that lets you drown a man in milk and macaroni. Nadezhda Petrovna, do you really think I won't be able to bring you to justice just because you pray with a gramophone? These days, even a gramophone can be convicted of counterrevolutionary activities.
OLIMP. You ought to keep it down about counterrevolutionaries, comrade. Her son is a communist.
IVAN. A communist? Then let him swear on a Bible at the police station that

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he is a communist.

OLIMP. What is the meaning of this, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. Well, it seems that he hasn't quite joined officially yet. But he definitely will, Olimp Valerianovich.

OLIMP. He hasn't joined yet? Are you telling me that you deceived me, Nadezhda Petrovna? You are downright seditious, Nadezhda Petrovna.

IVAN. That's right. Seditious.

OLIMP. Where is your dowry, Nadezhda Petrovna?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Where is the sturgeon pie, Nadezhda Petrovna?

DRUMMER. You're a liar, Nadezhda Petrovna.

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. You're a crook, Nadezhda Petrovna.

IVAN. You're a typical landlord, Nadezhda Petrovna. That's what you are.

SCENE FORTY

(Enter Pavel)

PAVEL. Silence! I'm a party member!

IVAN. You can't frighten me with that, now, Pavel Sergeyevich.

PAVEL. I can't frighten you, huh? And what if I'm Lunacharsky's² drinking buddy?

IVAN. What kind of communist are you, Pavel Sergeyevich? You don't even have any documents. There is no such thing as a communist without documents.

PAVEL. A document? You want a document?

IVAN. You don't have any, Pavel Sergeyevich.

PAVEL. I don't?

IVAN. You don't.

PAVEL. How about a warrant?

IVAN. You don't have a warrant either.

PAVEL. I don't? Then what's this?

IVAN. A warrant.

(Everyone runs out)

PAVEL. Mama, hold me back or I'll use this warrant to arrest all of Russia.

SCENE FORTY-ONE

NADEZHDA. Oh my God. The trunk is gone.

² Anatoly Lunacharsky was the first People's Commissar of Enlightenment.

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PAVEL. The trunk?

NADEZHDA. Pavlusha, the dress was in the trunk.

VARVARA. Yes, mama. And Nastya was in the dress.

PAVEL. Mama, what do you need a dress for when I have a warrant?

NADEZHDA. Pavel, you mean you really have a warrant?

PAVEL. Read it, mama, and you'll see.

NADEZHDA. "War-rant." Oh! I'd better not.

PAVEL. Read it, mama. Read it.

NADEZHDA. (*Reads*) "These presents have been presented to Pavel Sergeyevich Gulyachkin as proof that he does, in fact, live in the apartment he lives in. Official signature and seal affixed by..."

PAVEL. Read on, mama. Read on.

NADEZHDA. "...by the Chairman of the Housing Committee, Pavel Sergeyevich Gulyachkin."

PAVEL. A carbon copy has been sent to comrade Stalin.

END OF ACT II

ACT III

(A room in the Smetanich apartment)

SCENE ONE

AVTONOM. Agafangel, where is my copy of the "Tsarist News"?

SCENE TWO

(Enter Agafangel)

AGAFANGEL. Right here, your excellency.

AVTONOM. What are you doing?

AGAFANGEL. Pardon me, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Pardon what?

AGAFANGEL. I don't know, your excellency.

AVTONOM. What do you mean you don't know?

AGAFANGEL. There's no way of knowing, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Where is my copy of the "Tsarist News"?

AGAFANGEL. It has perished, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Perished?

AGAFANGEL. Totally, your excellency. So much so, that you can't even touch it anymore.

AVTONOM. Why not?

AGAFANGEL. Because all that is left is one big hole, your excellency.

AVTONOM. A hole?

AGAFANGEL. A hole, your excellency.

AVTONOM. How could that have happened?

AGAFANGEL. A law of nature, your excellency.

AVTONOM. A law? There is no such law. For example, I'm not young anymore either, but I don't have any holes in me.

AGAFANGEL. There is no point in comparing you to a newspaper, your excellency. After all, it would seem that you are a person.

AVTONOM. Don't pull the wool over my eyes. Tell me straight. You didn't, uh..., you couldn't have, uh..., in the bathroom?

AGAFANGEL. Absolutely not, your excellency.

AVTONOM. What?

AGAFANGEL. I don't know, your excellency.

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AVTONOM. Then why did you say "absolutely not"?

AGAFANGEL. It was just my ardor, your excellency.

AVTONOM. I'm asking you in plain Russian, were you, uh..., perhaps, reading it after me? Agafangel, you haven't taken up politics, have you?

AGAFANGEL. Your excellency, what need have I of politics when I am fully cared for?

AVTONOM. Well then, maybe you weren't as careful with it as you should have been?

AGAFANGEL. Absolutely not, your excellency. Every morning I wiped it off with a wet rag.

AVTONOM. Strange. Then how could it have perished? My, what a healthy issue it was! The print. The ideas. The letters. Why do you think that was? Because people then were great. Take Sytin, for example.¹ He published the newspaper "Russian Word." And, oh, how he did publish it! He built a three-story building and printed it on every floor. Every time you'd ride by, you'd think to yourself, "There it is. The bulwark of the Russian empire. The three-story 'Russian Word.'" Agafangel.

AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.

AVTONOM. What am I going to do now?

AGAFANGEL. Allow me to make a suggestion, your excellency.

AVTONOM. What suggestion?

AGAFANGEL. "The World Illustrated," your excellency. They print lots of pictures.

AVTONOM. Some trashy magazine, I imagine?

AGAFANGEL. Absolutely, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Well, go on. Read it to me. I can't see without my glasses.

AGAFANGEL. From the first page, your excellency?

AVTONOM. Begin at the beginning.

AGAFANGEL. There is a portrait, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Whose?

AGAFANGEL. His Highness, the Sovereign Emperor, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Attention! Give me my glasses. Where did you get this?

AGAFANGEL. In the bathroom, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Was there anybody else in there?

AGAFANGEL. There was, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Who?

AGAFANGEL. King Albert of Belgium. He was painted in among his subjects, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Where is he now?

AGAFANGEL. No sooner did I finish looking at him, I used him, your excellency.

¹ Ivan Sytin was a prominent Russian publisher before 1917.

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AVTONOM. Ah, a genuine martyr king. Hand me my handkerchief and read on.

AGAFANGEL. The commander-in-chief, Tsar Nikolai Nikolayevich, standing amidst a hurricane of enemy fire, is eating cabbage soup out of a common soldier's pot.

AVTONOM. Where are heroes like that now? Just think what an example he set. Every moment on the threshold of death, but he didn't flinch even when eating cabbage soup under a hurricane of enemy fire. What do you say to that, huh?

AGAFANGEL. Absolutely, your excellency. He could easily have died. Soldier's slop is worse than any poison known to man, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Agafangel.

AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Mix up some glue this instant. We have to glue these portraits to some heavy cardboard. One has to have a sense of responsibility. Otherwise, the commander-in-chief might be replaced by a hole.

AGAFANGEL. Right away, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Wait a minute. When you glue them to the cardboard, dry them out. And then bring them to me mornings with my coffee. I'll read them. I just can't live without politics. All my life I took an interest in politics every morning. Now go!

(Agafangel leaves)

SCENE THREE

(Enter Anatoly)

ANATOLY. You won't believe what interesting news I've got! You won't believe what interesting news I've got!

AVTONOM. What news?

ANATOLY. It turns out that there is no God.

AVTONOM. What do you mean?

ANATOLY. Simple. There's no such thing.

AVTONOM. In that case, young man, will you please tell me who has replaced Him?

ANATOLY. Hydrogen.

AVTONOM. What?

ANATOLY. Well, basically, gases of all kinds.

AVTONOM. Who told you that?

ANATOLY. At school they gave us a lecture with all kinds of strange pictures, uncle. And they showed us that there is no God anymore.

AVTONOM. No God. In that case, young man, you might tell me what

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everything we can see comes out of?
ANATOLY. Nature.
AVTONOM. Aha, and what did nature come out of?
ANATOLY. The air.
AVTONOM. Aha, and what did the air come out of?
ANATOLY. From..., I don't know....
AVTONOM. Aha! "I don't know!" It came out of God!
ANATOLY. But uncle, if all the air came out of God, then it's really true that
he doesn't exist.
AVTONOM. Anatoly.
ANATOLY. Yes, uncle.
AVTONOM. You will not be going to school anymore.
ANATOLY. Hurray! No more school.
AVTONOM. You aren't a little boy anymore, Anatoly. It's time for you to
become a person.
ANATOLY. What kind of person, uncle?
AVTONOM. What kind of person? Agafangel.

SCENE FOUR

(Enter Agafangel)

AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.
AVTONOM. Unveil it!

(Agafangel removes a sheet from a mannequin of a general in full regalia)

AVTONOM. That is the kind of person you'll become.
ANATOLY. How can I do that, uncle?
AVTONOM. Under my tutelage, it will be easy. At-ten-tion! You just wait.
The old days will return.
ANATOLY. Uncle, when will the old days come back to us?
AVTONOM. When will they come back to us? We have to go back to them.
ANATOLY. Then let's go as quick as possible, uncle.
AVTONOM. Left! Right! Left! Meanwhile, I'll just sit awhile. I get tired, you
know. Age. Agafangel.
AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.
AVTONOM. Sing!

(Agafangel and Anatoly march and sing)

Oh how Tsar Nikolai Nikolayevich would weep if only he could see us!
Agafangel!

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AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.

AVTONOM. If you were to see the tsar right now, what would you do?

AGAFANGEL. I would weep, your excellency.

AVTONOM. That's my man.

AGAFANGEL. My pleasure, your excellency.

AVTONOM. If there were only a hundred fine men like us with the tsar leading the way.... Strange, isn't it? What's taking him so long? Where is he? Oh, how weary we are of waiting.

SCENE FIVE

(Valerian and the Cabbie carry in the trunk)

VALERIAN. Careful. Careful. Ease it down. Ease it down. There. Thank you.

(The cabbie leaves)

SCENE SIX

AVTONOM. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, uncle.

AVTONOM. Why did you drag this thing in here?

VALERIAN. I did nothing of the sort.

AVTONOM. How's that?

VALERIAN. I didn't drag it anywhere. I saved it.

AVTONOM. How did you save it?

VALERIAN. You'll never be able to understand, uncle.

AVTONOM. Why not?

VALERIAN. Because I don't understand myself.

AVTONOM. Valerian, how is it that you don't understand what you yourself are doing?

VALERIAN. Uncle, I've never done anything before. I'm an anarchist. Anyway, judge for yourself. Right out of the blue, some man in a pot came running in.

AVTONOM. In a what?

VALERIAN. A pot. And he started screaming "police!" at the top of his lungs. Then a communist grabbed a drum and started beating on it with a stick.

AVTONOM. Those communists are all beasts. And then what happened?

VALERIAN. Then for some reason everybody disappeared into the other room with the guy in the pot and some strange lady fell on her knees in front of me.

AVTONOM. On her knees?

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VALERIAN. Yes.

AVTONOM. Typical Soviet woman.

VALERIAN. On the contrary, uncle. She was really quite decent.

AVTONOM. Decent? What could a decent woman want with you?

VALERIAN. You see, uncle, she divulged a state secret to me.

AVTONOM. A state secret? Consisting of what?

VALERIAN. Consisting of a trunk, uncle.

AVTONOM. A trunk? What's in the trunk?

VALERIAN. This trunk contains everything that is left of Russia in Russia.

AVTONOM. Valerian, what could possibly be left?

VALERIAN. I don't know, uncle. It's locked. I thought you might tell me.
After all, uncle, you're the politician in our family.

AVTONOM. What could be left of our Russia? Today there's only a hole
where yesterday there was the "Tsarist News."

ANATOLY. That's just what it is, a hole.

AVTONOM. Where's there a hole?

ANATOLY. I don't know, but it's leaking.

VALERIAN. Leaking? Oh, I'll say it's leaking.

AVTONOM. Then there must be an animal of some sort or maybe a person
in there.

VALERIAN. What do you think, uncle, what kind of animal or person could
be left of Russia in Russia?

AVTONOM. What kind of animal or person? Well, me for instance.

VALERIAN. And what else?

AVTONOM. You. And Patriarch Tikhon is also left of Russia in Russia.

VALERIAN. He may be left of Russia, uncle, but there's nothing of Russia
left in him.

AVTONOM. Y-e-s. A lot of water has gone under the bridge.

ANATOLY. There's another hole, uncle. And it's leaking too.

VALERIAN. Uncle, what if there really is a person in there? Psst! Pardon me,
are you a person?

VOICE OF NASTYA. No. I'm a woman.

ALL. A woman!

VALERIAN. Uncle, what woman could be left from Russia?

AVTONOM. A colonel I know once told me that he met one of the grand
duchesses on a beach in the Crimea.

VALERIAN. Which one, uncle?

AVTONOM. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, Valerian. Only, somehow I don't
believe it. The colonel was near-sighted from birth. Once he even confused
himself with a general.

VALERIAN. Even so, uncle, we've got to find out. Listen, please don't
consider me rude, but what is your name?

VOICE OF NASTYA. Nastya.

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VALERIAN. What?

VOICE OF NASTYA. Anastasiya.

ALL. It's her!

AVTONOM. My God, it's her. Lord, what are we going to do?

VALERIAN. Maybe it's a different Anastasiya. I'll ask her a question.

AVTONOM. "I'll ask her a question," he says. If it is the grand duchess, how are you going to do that? There's nothing in the regulation book concerning a situation like this.

VALERIAN. I'll ask her a question as if I don't know anything. Oh, by the way, mademoiselle, what was your father's name?

VOICE OF NASTYA. Nikolai.

AVTONOM. Agafangel.

AGAFANGEL. Yes, Avtonom Sigismundovich.

AVTONOM. Hold me!

SCENE SEVEN

(Enter Olimp)

OLIMP. Gentlemen, I hear there are rumblings against Soviet power in Poland again.

AVTONOM. Who cares about Poland when you don't even know what is going on in your own home?

OLIMP. I don't understand.

VALERIAN. Pardon me, papa, but I saved Russia.

OLIMP. How did you save Russia?

VALERIAN. Absolutely by chance.

AVTONOM. Olimp, he saved one of the grand duchesses.

OLIMP. What?

AVTONOM. It's true, Olimp.

VALERIAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, papa.

OLIMP. Anastasiya Nikolayevna? It can't be.

VALERIAN. How can't it be when she said so herself?

OLIMP. But where is she then?

AVTONOM. Right here, Olimp. In the trunk.

OLIMP. In the trunk? Then we've got to liberate her.

AVTONOM. We have to arrange a proper reception.

VALERIAN. A reception? One second, uncle. *(Leaves)*

SCENE EIGHT

OLIMP. Are you sure you're not mistaken, gentlemen? Are you certain it's

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her?

AVTONOM. Why do you think they would be keeping a live woman under lock and key if she wasn't a duchess or something?

SCENE NINE

(Valerian returns with a roll of French bread and some salt)

AVTONOM. Valerian.

VALERIAN. Yes, uncle.

AVTONOM. What is that for?

VALERIAN. It's bread and salt for an official reception. Unfortunately, the bread is a day old.

AVTONOM. However, fortunately it's French bread. I think she'll like that. After all, Valerian, the only true Russian patriots left are all French. Stand over here, Valerian. Anatoly, grab a flower. It will be more ceremonious.

ANATOLY. Will a cactus do, uncle?

AVTONOM. Oh Lord, what a moment! Just think, our entire future is about to rise before our eyes!

ANATOLY. Uncle, open it up quickly. Otherwise she's going to drip out entirely.

AVTONOM. Are you ready, gentlemen?

All. Ready.

AVTONOM. Here we go.

VALERIAN. Do you realize what you are opening, uncle?

AVTONOM. What?

VALERIAN. A new page in history.

AVTONOM. Agafangel.

AGAFANGEL. Yes, Avtonom Sigismundovich.

AVTONOM. Line the route. Attention! *(Opens the trunk)*

NASTYA. *(Crawling out)* Where am I?

AVTONOM. Among loyal subjects, Your Highness.

NASTYA. Sir, you are mistaken.

AVTONOM. I swear to you, Your Highness.

NASTYA. Oh, come now.

OLIMP. Believe us, Your Highness. Your Highness, if we had known that you were in Moscow all this time...

NASTYA. On the contrary. I only arrived recently.

OLIMP. Were you alone, Your Highness?

NASTYA. You seem prone to make errors all the time, sir.

OLIMP. Excuse me, Your Highness. Who were you with?

NASTYA. What a funny fellow. I was with my uncle.

AVTONOM. What! Then the Grand Duke Mikhail Alexandrovich has also

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returned to Moscow? Hurrah!
ALL. Hurrah!
NASTYA. Ah!
OLIMP. What is the matter, Your Highness?
NASTYA. I think I'm all wet.
VALERIAN. Papa, she doesn't feel well.
AVTONOM. Hold her! Hold her!
ANATOLY. She fell right on the cactus. Look, she's all wet.
OLIMP. We must undress her immediately or she'll catch cold.
VALERIAN. Allow me, papa.
AVTONOM. Valerian, you should be ashamed to say a thing like that. You're not a boy, anymore, Valerian.
ANATOLY. In that case, uncle, let me. I'm still a boy.
AVTONOM. Anatoly! That's enough indecency from you! I will do it. Don't forget, our task is the salvation of Russia.
VALERIAN. But uncle, it was me who saved Russia. How come others get to undress her?
AVTONOM. You saved her? How did you save her? Like a coward, in a cab. While I...
OLIMP. Avtonom, don't forget it was I who said first that we should liberate her.
ANATOLY. But papa, it was the leaky hole that led us to her and I discovered the hole.
AVTONOM. What's the hole got to do with it when I was the one?
OLIMP. No, I did it.
VALERIAN. No, I did it.
All. No, I did it.
AGAFANGEL. Avtonom Sigismundovich.
AVTONOM. What do you want?
AGAFANGEL. If you keep this up, there will soon be nothing left of her but a wet spot.
OLIMP. What are we doing, gentlemen? Carry her to bed.

(All except Olimp pick up Nastya)

AVTONOM. Just think, in the old days, it took all of Russia to carry people like this on their backs. Now, four people is more than plenty.

(They carry her out)

SCENE TEN

OLIMP. *(At the telephone)* If I hadn't seen her with my own eyes, I would

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never have believed it. Five, sixteen, sixty-four, please. Thank you. Stepan Stepanovich? Stepan Stepanovich, news from the most trustworthy sources. Immediately drop whatever you're doing and start buying stocks. What? Tsarist stocks. No, no, I feel fine. I'm telling you, this comes from the most trustworthy sources. I can't. You know perfectly well there's a commissar sitting on every line. Oh, all right. I'll tell you in German, then. They're all peasants and they don't know any German. All right, listen. Just a second. Just a second. Damn! I forgot the word. I know I studied it once. Well, in a word, they've returned to Moscow... Moscow, you understand? That's right. Moscow. The gross grand Fürstin. Fürstin. The grand duchess, get it? Anastasiya Nikolayevna. In German they say that just like we do. Und..., und..., and, get it? And. Und the Grossfürst, too. It's the same thing, gross..., gross..., that means big. The grand duke, get it? Michel. Michel. Oh, come on. Mikhail, understand? That's right. Mikhail Alexandrovich. You understand me? Only please, don't tell a soul. Whew! There you have it! A good education will always come to a man's rescue.

SCENE ELEVEN

(Agafangel with the dress, Avtonom and Valerian return)

AVTONOM. Shh. Her Highness is sleeping.

OLIMP. Gentlemen, while her Highness is asleep, let's decide what we're going to do next.

VALERIAN. I think we ought to walk on tiptoe, papa.

OLIMP. And I think you ought to marry Varvara Sergeyevna instantly. Any minute now we may need to fall back on our own personal communist.

VALERIAN. All right, papa. But only on one condition.

OLIMP. What's that?

VALERIAN. Only if Varvara Sergeyevna is going to be my kept woman.

OLIMP. How can she be your kept woman if you're getting married today in a church?

VALERIAN. You misunderstood me, papa. In fact, she'll be my wife. Only I'll tell my friends that she's my kept woman so as not to feel ashamed.

OLIMP. I suppose that will be more seemly.

(The telephone rings)

Who could that be? Hello? Oh, it's you Mister Ilinkin. What? Can you trust Stepan Stepanovich? What? Stocks and bonds? Buy! Buy! Yes. In whatever quantity you can. What? Very much so. I recommend it. Yes. They've arrived. From the most trustworthy sources. It should soon be all over. Only please, don't tell a soul. Good-bye. All right Valerian, get ready and

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I'll send for Nadezhda Petrovna.

(Valerian leaves. During this conversation, Agafangel carries the trunk into the next room)

SCENE TWELVE

AVTONOM. You know, Olimp, I think it would be a good idea for her Highness the Empress to change her name for awhile. Otherwise, we might not be able to get her a housing permit. What if the housing committee figured out who she is?

OLIMP. Yes. The name Romanov might attract attention.

SCENE THIRTEEN

(Enter Nadezhda)

NADEZHDA. Olimp Valerianovich, don't believe that desperado. For God's sake, don't believe him.

OLIMP. What happened, Nadezhda Petrovna?

AVTONOM. What's going on?

NADEZHDA. Olimp Valerianovich, he may have told you that he's an honest person, but that's just a smoke screen.

OLIMP. Who? I don't understand.

NADEZHDA. Ivan Ivanovich.

OLIMP. What Ivan Ivanovich?

NADEZHDA. Ivan Ivanovich Shironkin. Our boarder.

AVTONOM. What did he say?

NADEZHDA. "Nadezhda Petrovna," he says, "I know that your son is no communist because his ancestors are all parasites." I lived in full legal matrimony with my husband for nineteen years and, just imagine, this man has the nerve to tell me my son is the product of parasites. So I said, "Ivan Ivanovich, why are you spreading such a disgusting legend about my offspring?" And he says, "I can prove to any citizen that your son is a parasitic element because he doesn't work anywhere." And I said, "But why should he work anywhere when, by profession, he is unemployed?" And he said, "I don't care. I'll prove it anyway."

OLIMP. Pardon the expression, but what kind of a moron is he trying to prove things like that to?

NADEZHDA. You, Olimp Valerianovich. You. Only don't believe him, Olimp Valerianovich. For God's sake don't believe him.

OLIMP. I wouldn't even think of listening to him, Nadezhda Petrovna.

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NADEZHDA. Olimp Valerianovich, who could possibly think that my Pavlusha is not a communist when, you yourself, Olimp Valerianovich, saw that he has a genuine warrant? And what a potent warrant it is! You may believe it or not, but I couldn't sleep a wink all night long. Olimp Valerianovich, I couldn't stop thinking, what if he arrests me? What if he arrests me?

AVTONOM. What are you talking about? What would he arrest his own mother for?

NADEZHDA. Avtonom Sigismundovich, you simply can't imagine what a terrible ideologue he is. He's like a drunken fool with this idea in his head, Avtonom Sigismundovich. You even come near him and he says, "I'll arrest everybody." I'm afraid he got that from his father. Whenever his father would get drunk he'd say, "Let me out of here. I want to go abroad and make mincemeat of all those Germans."

OLIMP. What for?

NADEZHDA. "Let 'em all bow down before the Russian God," he used to say.

AVTONOM. You mean your son is really that ferocious?

NADEZHDA. He's ferocious, all right, Avtonom Sigismundovich. He's ferocious. But when he's in the company of his higher-ups, Avtonom Sigismundovich, he's as gentle as a little birdie.

AVTONOM. What birdie?

NADEZHDA. A pigeon, Avtonom Sigismundovich, a pigeon. Or maybe it's a crane.

AVTONOM. Why a crane?

NADEZHDA. Because he balances on one leg, Avtonom Sigismundovich.

OLIMP. I like your son, Nadezhda Petrovna.

NADEZHDA. You know how we want to please you, Olimp Valerianovich. And as for my daughter Varya, Olimp Valerianovich, she has completely lost her appetite because of your son. It happens whenever we're at the dinner table and she starts thinking about Valerian Olimpovich, Olimp Valerianovich. Even the most tasty morsel gets stuck in her throat. And she says, "Mama, I've seen a lot of terribly handsome men, but Valerian Olimpovich is the most terrible of them all."

OLIMP. In that case, Nadezhda Petrovna, why put off the wedding?

NADEZHDA. My dear Olimp Valerianovich, you mean you've decided?

OLIMP. I want to do it today, Nadezhda Petrovna. Today. Only there is one small condition.

NADEZHDA. What condition is that, Olimp Valerianovich?

OLIMP. Nadezhda Petrovna, I want your son to move in with us today.

NADEZHDA. Oh, Olimp Valerianovich, our whole family is planning to move in with you.

OLIMP. What? Don't frighten me like that, Nadezhda Petrovna. No, why

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would you want to do that?

NADEZHDA. Don't worry, Olimp Valerianovich. It will be no problem at all. We'll just pack up our things and head on over.

OLIMP. He doesn't need any things, Nadezhda Petrovna. All he needs is his warrant.

NADEZHDA. Olimp Valerianovich, he never so much as takes a step without his warrant. This morning when he came home from the bath-house he said, "I took my whole bath with my scrub brush in my right hand and my warrant in my left hand. Let everybody see I'm a bigwig even when I'm naked."

OLIMP. I see. Well, we'll be expecting you, Nadezhda Petrovna.... Listen, Avtonom, could you.... God be with you, Nadezhda Petrovna, it's time for you to go.

NADEZHDA. I'm going, Olimp Valerianovich. I'm going.

OLIMP. Can't you do it a little more quickly, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. In a flash, Olimp Valerianovich. In a flash. Just like a... horse.
(Leaves)

SCENE FOURTEEN

OLIMP. What is it, Avtonom?

AVTONOM. (*At the telephone*) It's Zarkhin, Olimp.

OLIMP. What does he want?

AVTONOM. He recommends you buy up stocks, Olimp.

OLIMP. What stocks?

AVTONOM. "What stocks," he says. Tsarist? He says Tsarist stocks, Olimp. Yes, yes. I hear you. Olimp, he says... who arrived? Who? Who arrived? The Grand Duke Mikhail Alexandrovich? The Grand Duke Mikhail Alexandrovich has arrived in Moscow. What? What? Olimp! Anastasiya Nikolayevna arrived too! Of course. Of course. Don't you worry. Olimp, he begs you not to tell a soul.

OLIMP. Well, if Zarkhin himself knows about it, then it must be true.

(*Both leave*)

SCENE FIFTEEN

(*Enter Ivan*)

IVAN. What a shame that I never finished college or anything. It would come in handy in a conversation with a man like Olimp Valerianovich. I think someone is coming.

SCENE SIXTEEN

(Enter Nastya)

IVAN. What splendid scenery.

NASTYA. What happened to my dress?

IVAN. A nymph draped in nothing but a sheet. I wonder what I should do?

NASTYA. Ah! Don't look at me!

IVAN. Mademoiselle, don't think I'm insolent because you are undressed.

NASTYA. Well, I'll be. I thought there was a man in here, but it turns out it's just you, Ivan Ivanovich.

IVAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna! What are you doing here?

NASTYA. Incidentally, I don't even know where I am.

IVAN. How is it you don't know where you are, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, when you're wandering around naked like you own the place?

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, it's not my fault that my dress was sunk.

IVAN. What do you mean, your dress was sunk?

NASTYA. Naturally, I don't expect you to believe it, but I stand before you a drowned woman.

IVAN. Drowned? Where did you drown?

NASTYA. On a chair.

IVAN. If you take me for a total fool, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, you'll never be able to convince me of it.

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, one might say I'm a walking disaster zone, and meanwhile, you do nothing but doubt.

IVAN. Pardon me, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, but how did you get here?

NASTYA. How? Partly by cab and partly by hand.

IVAN. By hand? What are you, Anastasiya Nikolayevna? An actress? Only actors walk on their hands.

NASTYA. First of all, actresses walk on their own hands. I came here on somebody else's hands.

IVAN. Somebody else's?

NASTYA. That's right.

IVAN. Through the streets?

NASTYA. That's right.

IVAN. Draped in a sheet?

NASTYA. What, do you think I'm a cheap woman or something?

IVAN. What were you in then?

NASTYA. A trunk.

IVAN. I don't get it, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. You'd better explain everything to me from the beginning.

NASTYA. All right, Ivan Ivanovich. Let's take it from the beginning. First they dressed me in a gorgeous dress. Then they drenched me with water.

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Then they stuffed me in a trunk and brought me here.
IVAN. I don't get it. And what did they do with you when you got here?
NASTYA. They undressed me and took me to bed.
IVAN. Now I get it, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. You've gone down the road to ruin.
NASTYA. You don't say!
IVAN. As God is my witness.
NASTYA. Listen, that's not very nice.
IVAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, you should know that your Nadezhda Petrovna is a trader in live goods.
NASTYA. You'll never make me believe even that.
IVAN. Then why do you think she would take chaste maidens, pack them in trunks and send them off to strange men?
NASTYA. What are they going to do with me, Ivan Ivanovich?
IVAN. I think Olimp Valerianovich wants to make you his favorite.
NASTYA. His what?
IVAN. His favorite, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. In other words, a cook of earthly delights.
NASTYA. Oh, mama! They want to drive an unmarried woman into shame. Wait a minute, Ivan Ivanovich. Maybe it's like in "The Bloody Martyr Queen"?
IVAN. What happens in "The Bloody Martyr Queen"?
NASTYA. That's a story about how a cultured milord abducts a nondescript mademoiselle from the lower classes and marries her in a Catholic Church for reasons of passionate love.
IVAN. Anastasiya Nikolayevna, there is no such thing as love in the Soviet state. The only thing we have left is the problem of sex. And furthermore, why should a man like Olimp Valerianovich want to marry you when he's got so much money he doesn't know what to do with it all? I really turned out to be a fool. I thought I'd come to Olimp Valerianovich and denounce Pavel Sergeyevich as a parasitic element. But it turns out they're all birds of a feather.
NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, what do I do now?
IVAN. What can we do, Anastasiya Nikolayevna?! You are a fallen woman.
NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, you're an educated man. Do something!

(Ivan kneels and kisses Nastya's hand)

IVAN. I bow not before you, but before your suffering. Farewell, Anastasiya Nikolayevna, I must leave you.
NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich, let me go with you!
IVAN. Where can you go looking like that, Anastasiya Nikolayevna? Any citizen might lodge a complaint with any policeman that you are trying to

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turn the public streets into a private bathhouse.

NASTYA. Ivan Ivanovich reject not my prayers! Stay with me! Defend me!

IVAN. Here? Come now, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. If Olimp Valerianovich were to find us here in such intimate circumstances, you can forget elevators. He'd throw me down the stairs. Wait! Shh! Somebody's coming. Hide me, Anastasiya Nikolayevna! Hide me! Otherwise, it's down the stairs for sure.

NASTYA. Defend me, Ivan Ivanovich! Defend me!

IVAN. Crawl back here! Crawl back here! (*He sets up a screen*)

(*Nastya and Ivan hide behind it*)

For God's sake, at least cover my head with your sheet, otherwise they might find me!

SCENE SEVENTEEN

(*Enter Olimp, Valerian and Avtonom*)

OLIMP. Are you sure the dress is dry?

AVTONOM. It's dry, Olimp. It's dry.

NASTYA. Don't come back here, please. There's a naked woman here.

OLIMP. Pardon me. I see it pleased you to rise, Your Highness. Shall you command us to dress you, Your Highness?

IVAN. What did I tell you? He's made you his favorite.

NASTYA. Now the problems begin.

AVTONOM. Would you care to bathe yourself, Your Highness? Here's a wash tub.

IVAN. A wash tub? Aha. Just as I figured.

NASTYA. You can kill me if you want, but I will not be dishonored.

OLIMP. Forgive me, Your Highness. If you misunderstood me, Your Highness, then please believe me, it was unintended, Your Highness.

NASTYA. You can't fool me with intonations like that. I won't stay here for anything.

OLIMP. But, Your Highness, how could you doubt the passionate loyalty and love of a true Russian?

NASTYA. Love? You're teasing.

OLIMP. I swear it, Your Highness.

AVTONOM. Stay with us, Your Highness.

NASTYA. But what if someone finds out the situation I'm in here? No, I'd better leave.

OLIMP. We implore you, Your Highness. Stay with us. We'll give you a new name. I'll take it all on myself, Your Highness.

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NASTYA. Are you blowing hot air or is that the truth?

VALERIAN. As God is our witness, Your Highness.

NASTYA. What did I tell you, Ivan Ivanovich. Just like in "The Bloody Martyr Queen." My dear boy, I accept. Only why do you keep calling me "Your Highness"?

VALERIAN. Have no fear, Your Highness. No one will hear us.

NASTYA. But when we get married, will you call me Nastya?

VALERIAN. What do you mean, when we get married?

OLIMP. Avtonom. Water. I need a glass of water!

IVAN. You hear that? He's backing down.

VALERIAN. Papa, I think I'm going to be sick.

IVAN. You hear that? He's backing down.

NASTYA. Listen here, you are terribly heartless. Why did you just declare your love and offer to give me a new name?

AVTONOM. Answer her, Valerian! Answer her!

VALERIAN. Uncle, I can't. My head is spinning. I've got the hiccups.

AVTONOM. Olimp, what's wrong with you?

OLIMP. Just a second. Your Highness, could he possibly dream of such happiness?

NASTYA. You mean he's agreed?

IVAN. Help! My pot is busted.

OLIMP. What's that, Your Highness?

NASTYA. It's nothing. I was just talking to myself. And if you think that my voice has changed, that's only because I caught a cold.

AVTONOM. What is wrong with you, Olimp? Ask her! Ask her!

VALERIAN. Papa, ask her!

OLIMP. When would it suit you, Your Highness?

NASTYA. When would what suit me?

OLIMP. In the event that you've forgotten, Your Highness, I have in mind the wedding ceremony.

NASTYA. Oh, that. Right away.

IVAN. They'll deceive you, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. I'm telling you they'll deceive you. And, anyway, how am I going to get out of here? How am I going to get out of here?

VALERIAN. Papa, look at her leg.

OLIMP. I see, Valerian. You can tell in an instant she's from the nobility.

NASTYA. Listen, close your eyes for just a minute. I'd like to go into the next room.

AVTONOM. Close your eyes, gentlemen! Close your eyes!

OLIMP. Our eyes are closed, Your Highness.

NASTYA. Now get out of here, Ivan Ivanovich. Only do it quietly. Like this. On tiptoe.

IVAN. I'm sunk.

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NASTYA. What?

IVAN. I'm sunk, Anastasiya Nikolayevna. I hear somebody coming.

NASTYA. That was just me sniffing, gentlemen. Don't pay it any mind. *(To Ivan)* Hide somewhere. Anywhere. I'll get you out later.

SCENE EIGHTEEN

(The same, minus Ivan)

NASTYA. Hand me my toilet, please.

OLIMP. Certainly, Your Highness.

NASTYA. I'll be ready shortly. *(Leaves)*

SCENE NINETEEN

(Enter Anatoly at a run)

ANATOLY. Papa, the carriage has arrived.

AVTONOM. Anatoly, shut your eyes.

OLIMP. What carriage?

ANATOLY. The wedding carriage. For Valerian and Varvara Sergeyevna.

OLIMP. What Varvara Sergeyevna?

AVTONOM. Oh my God. They'll be here soon.

OLIMP. I forgot. I totally forgot. What are we going to do, Valerian?

VALERIAN. I don't know, papa. My head is spinning.

OLIMP. Avtonom, is that you?

ANATOLY. It's me, papa. It's not him, it's me. Me.

OLIMP. Oh, it's you? Then where are you, Avtonom?

AVTONOM. Here he is.

OLIMP. Avtonom, won't you please go inform them as diplomatically as possible that the wedding is off?

AVTONOM. Diplomatically? I'll try, Olimp. I'll try. But, just think, Olimp.

Can you believe what has happened? At the present moment, this woman stands as the last representative of all Russia. And he is going to marry her.

OLIMP. That's right, Avtonom. One might even say he has become the bridegroom of all Russia. What a responsibility.

AVTONOM. And what a dowry.

VALERIAN. Ah!

AVTONOM. Pardon me, Anatoly.

VALERIAN. That's strange, uncle. You boxed my ear but you beg Anatoly's pardon.

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SCENE TWENTY

(Enter Nastya)

NASTYA. Here I am, gentlemen. Dressed and hoofed.

OLIMP. Your Highness, the carriage is ready.

NASTYA. Shall we go, then?

(Nastya, Olimp and Valerian leave)

SCENE TWENTY-ONE

AVTONOM. So, Anatoly. You will soon be the brother of the Empress, her Highness.

ANATOLY. If only mama were still alive, uncle, wouldn't she be happy?

SCENE TWENTY-TWO

(Enter Agafangel with glue)

AGAFANGEL. Here is your glue, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Glue? What glue? Oh, yes. Anatoly.

ANATOLY. Yes, uncle.

AVTONOM. Right now, you and I are going to glue this picture to a piece of cardboard.

ANATOLY. Uncle, is that the uncle of the woman who was in the trunk?

AVTONOM. Yes, Anatoly. The Sovereign of Russia.

ANATOLY. What do we need him for now?

AGAFANGEL. To take with morning coffee, Anatoly Olimpovich.

AVTONOM. To take with coffee?! To embolden our spirits! What are a people without a tsar? Orphans, that's what. Everything in nature has a tsar. Take a bird, for example. Say, a sparrow or a duck. Even they have a tsar. Anatoly.

ANATOLY. Yes, uncle.

AVTONOM. Who is the tsar of the birds?

ANATOLY. The eagle, uncle.

AVTONOM. Agafangel.

AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Who is the tsar of the beasts?

AGAFANGEL. The pig, your excellency.

AVTONOM. The pig? What pig? Why the pig?

AGAFANGEL. Because a pig is tough, your excellency.

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AVTONOM. What is so tough about a pig?

AGAFANGEL. Pig's feet, your excellency.

ANATOLY. Uncle, I've already smeared the Grand Duke. What do you want me to stick him on?

AVTONOM. Agafangel, go find some cardboard. And don't forget to peek into the bathroom and see whether anyone else is in there. Otherwise, the Grand Duchess might happen upon another of her close relatives.

(Agafangel leaves)

SCENE TWENTY-THREE

ANATOLY. Where should I put it, uncle?

AVTONOM. Set in on the chair for now.

(Anatoly sets the portrait of the Tsar on the chair, glued side up)

SCENE TWENTY-FOUR

(Enter Nadezhda, Varvara in a wedding dress and Pavel with a portrait)

NADEZHDA. Thank God, we've finally arrived, Avtonom Sigismundovich.

AVTONOM. Oh, what a spot! How am I going to say this diplomatically?

NADEZHDA. These, Avtonom Sigismundovich, are my children.

AVTONOM. I sympathize with you terribly, Nadezhda Petrovna. But, as God is my witness, it isn't my fault.

NADEZHDA. Pardon me?

AVTONOM. How am I going to tell them?

NADEZHDA. Where is the groom, Avtonom Sigismundovich?

VARVARA. Mama, don't say things like that. I get embarrassed.

AVTONOM. I wholeheartedly concur, mademoiselle. It's best not to talk about it.

ANATOLY. If you mean my brother, he left with my papa to get married.

NADEZHDA. Saints alive! Here we stand talking nonsense and they're waiting for us at the church! Pavel, powder Varvara's nose. Let's go, Avtonom Sigismundovich! Let's go!

AVTONOM. The thing is, Nadezhda Petrovna, I've got to tell you...

NADEZHDA. Oh, my goodness! I forgot. Just a minute, Avtonom Sigismundovich. Varya, get down on your knees.

VARVARA. But we...

NADEZHDA. Varya, don't hold things up. Avtonom Sigismundovich, we'll be ready in just a moment.

THE WARRANT — ACT III

(Varvara kneels. Nadezhda begins weeping and wailing. Pavel powders Varvara's nose)

VARVARA. Mama, please don't drip on my dress. Cry over there, mama. Drip on the floor.

AVTONOM. What is wrong, Nadezhda Petrovna?

NADEZHDA. Oh, I'm giving you and your mother away to a stranger's father! But a stranger can never be a father to you. And a stranger can never be a mother to you. Oh, fathers! Oh, mothers! *(She weeps and wails)*

AVTONOM. Nadezhda Petrovna, I am very pleased that things have taken such a turn. There's no need to suffer so, Nadezhda Petrovna. The wedding is off.

THE THREE GULYACHKINS. What do you mean?

AVTONOM. Don't worry, Nadezhda Petrovna, there will be no wedding.

VARVARA. Mama, I think I've just been humiliated.

NADEZHDA. What do you mean, there will be no wedding? Why not?

AVTONOM. I'm afraid I can't tell you that.

NADEZHDA. Saints alive, what is going on? They've humiliated us, that's what they've done. They've humiliated us. Mister Avtonom Sigismundovich, what have we done to displease Valerian Olimpovich? It would seem that my daughter is perfectly plump and is incapable of being humiliated. If he thinks that Varya's nose isn't very successful, he should know that even without her nose she'll make a very pleasant spouse.

VARVARA. In fact, Avtonom Sigismundovich, if you look at it from a different point of view, you'll see that it is quite prominent. Quite prominent, really.

ANATOLY. I think I can see that.

AVTONOM. The problem is not in her nose, Nadezhda Petrovna, it's much deeper.

VARVARA. Deeper? Avtonom Sigismundovich, even deeper I have....

AVTONOM. I believe you. I believe you. But, please understand, Varvara Sergeyevna, you are not the problem.

NADEZHDA. Then who is, Avtonom Sigismundovich? Who is? If I am the problem, Avtonom Sigismundovich, you should know that I am just her mother. Nothing but rubbish and nonsense, Avtonom Sigismundovich.

AVTONOM. I agree with you wholeheartedly, Nadezhda Petrovna, only....

NADEZHDA. Were I in Valerian Olimpovich's place, I wouldn't pay me the slightest attention.

AVTONOM. You are absolutely right, Nadezhda Petrovna. However, the problem lies elsewhere.

NADEZHDA. What is the problem, Avtonom Sigismundovich?

AVTONOM. That, Nadezhda Petrovna, is a secret, and I can't explain it to you.

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NADEZHDA. You can't? Pavlusha, you're obstinate. You talk with him, please.

PAVEL. Listen here, young man! Are you trying to drag our family's collective nose through the dirt? Why is the wedding off?

AVTONOM. Don't you dare talk to me like that.

PAVEL. Don't dare? And what if I'm accustomed to having intimate chats with the Third Internationale? What will you do then?

AVTONOM. Now I've had it. Now he's going to arrest me.

PAVEL. I'll have you know that I went underground for the whole October Revolution. And you tell me, "don't dare"!

AVTONOM. He's going to shoot me.

PAVEL. For all you know, I might be a chairman..., of a housing committee. I am an autocrat!

AVTONOM. My apologies, comrade. I didn't....

PAVEL. Silence! I am a party man.

ANATOLY. Shut up! I am the brother of her Highness!

(Pavel sits on the chair)

SCENE TWENTY-FIVE

(Enter Stepan Stepanovich and his wife Felitsiata Gordeyevna carrying flowers)

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. Christ is risen, Avtonom Sigismundovich. Pay no attention to my kisses, because my spirit is as pure as an Easter service.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Forgive me for failing to inquire about your health, but one must put the interests of the motherland above all.

SCENE TWENTY-SIX

(Enter Ilinkin and Ilinkina)

ILINKIN. Ladies and gentlemen! Please don't tell me that Mikhail Alexandrovich is a bad joke.

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. Listen here. How can you put such a question so tastelessly?

SCENE TWENTY-SEVEN

(Enter Zotik Frantsevich Zarkhin, Ariadna Pavlinovna Zarkhina and their daughters Tosya and Syusya)

THE WARRANT — ACT III

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. You can't imagine how self-assured these bolsheviks are. Just now my husband and I were walking along the street and a policeman was standing on the corner pretending that nothing has happened.

SCENE TWENTY-EIGHT

(Enter Narkis Smaragdovich Krantik)

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. What do you think, wouldn't an eight-by-twelve be splendid?

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. What eight-by-twelve?

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. Well, I thought it might be nice to fix this moment for posterity.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Fix what?

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. The renaissance.

ILINKIN. What renaissance?

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. The rebirth. The rebirth of our long-suffering motherland. This event is bound to send shock-waves through all of Russia. As such, I've decided a cabinet picture is the most appropriate. Eight-by-twelve. *(Pulls out a large camera)*

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. Stepan, it's a photographer.

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. Narkis Smaragdovich Krantik at your service. Amateur photographer. Having learned under sworn secret that the empress, her Highness is here....

PAVEL. What highness? Here?

AVTONOM. The cat is out of the bag. Hold him! Hold him! Agafangel!

SCENE TWENTY-NINE

(Enter Agafangel)

AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Cover all the exits!

(Holding a pistol, Agafangel takes a position by the door)

VOICES. What happened? What's going on? What is this?

AVTONOM. Gentlemen, they've been spying on us.

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Who has been spying on us?

AVTONOM. The communists.

ALL. Communists!

THE MAJOR PLAYS OF NIKOLAI ERDMAN

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. Every man for himself!

(Everyone races for the door)

AGAFANGEL. Stop or I'll shoot!

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Help! They've got us surrounded!

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. It looks to me like there's only one communist.

Let's try surrounding him.

AVTONOM. That's right, gentlemen! Surround him! Surround him!

VARVARA. Mama, if they kill Pavel, it will simply be a nightmare.

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Gentlemen, don't surround him only from behind. Surround him in front, too. No need to fear, Mister Ilinkin. Go ahead, surround him in front.

ALL. Surround him! Surround him!

PAVEL. Mama, I am perishing in the clutches of the bourgeoisie.

NADEZHDA. Good people, don't cause the ruination of a Christian believer.

Avtonom Sigismundovich, it's true that if you look at him from one angle he's a communist, but if you look at him from another...

PAVEL. From the other I'm nothing of the sort. *(He stands and bows. The portrait of Tsar Nikolai has stuck to his rear end)*

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Zotik, don't believe him! Don't believe him, Zotik! Don't go near him!

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. But we have got to discern his true face.

TOSYA. Papa, he has two of them.

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. What do you mean, two?

TOSYA. Well, papa, I'm a bit ashamed to say it, but he has a face on his rear end.

ALL. Where?

TOSYA. Right here.

AVTONOM. All right, young man. Bend over. Oh my God! Attention!

PAVEL. Mama, whose face am I wearing back there? Mine?

ANATOLY. No. It's ours.

SCENE THIRTY

(Enter Valerian and Guests)

VALERIAN. Gentlemen, prepare yourselves. Her Highness is coming.

ALL. She's coming!

AVTONOM. Gentlemen, she's coming.

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Is she almost here?

VALERIAN. Almost, madame, almost. *(Runs out)*

SCENE THIRTY-ONE

ILINKIN. Finally! Capital will return to the capitalists.

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. I always told you it couldn't last.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Indeed, how could it have gone on when they have utterly destroyed the whole country. Top to bottom. Beginning with our factory and ending with our candy store.

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. They called us labor exploiters and they said they supported free labor. I suppose that if free labor means the whole country is out of work, then they were right. Only I can't see what's so good about that.

ILINKINA. Who cares about your candy store when I had all my silver spoons confiscated in nineteen-nineteen?

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Look at what's happened to the schools! They're nothing but a den of thieves. Boys study in one class with girls! Maybe they can study algebra or music together, but what about anatomy class?

AVTONOM. Ariadna Pavlinovna, just imagine what might have happened if in the old days I had studied anatomy with girls.

ILINKINA. Who cares about anatomy when I had all my silver spoons confiscated in nineteen-nineteen?

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. Who cares about school when you can't even go out on the streets anymore? In peacetime there was art everywhere. Take the monument of General Skobelev, for example. You'd look at him and you could just feel what a pleasant sight that was for sore eyes. Now look at the statue they replaced him with. Pardon the expression, but it looks to me like the new guy is making obscene gestures.

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. That's just what it is, an obscene gesture. I always go for walks on that square and I know just what you're talking about.

ILINKINA. Who cares about obscene gestures when I had all my silver spoons confiscated in nineteen-nineteen?

ILINKIN. Gentlemen, have you noticed what they have done with religious people? Take me, for example. Every Sunday I get an urge for religion, but they've put kindergartens in all the churches. As a result, you either have to travel all the way across town to get your religion or you have to go without it altogether.

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. How can you go without religion? For example, every Sunday I read the Bible to Tosya and Syusya. It is so ennobling, so ennobling. So much so that I don't even recognize my little Tosya any more.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Yes, it's terribly difficult with children these days. Tell me, mademoiselle, do you have children?

VARVARA. Oh come now, I would never allow myself something like that.

NADEZHDA. My good man, she is a bride.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. A bride? There, you see? What has happened to the family these days? Fathers are bachelors, mothers are married and their children are all orphans.

NADEZHDA. You're absolutely right. What a state we are in! In the old days we lived a real life. But what do we have now? A utopia.

FELITSIATA GORDEYEVNA. Well, thank God, the utopia is about to end.

AVTONOM. We put up long enough with the revolution. Now let it put up with us.

SCENE THIRTY-TWO

(Enter Valerian)

GUEST. Ladies and gentleman, they are approaching.

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. They're approaching! Stop, gentlemen! Stop!

AVTONOM. Young man, get down on all fours this minute. Face the door. What, are you deaf, young man? I am telling you, face the door. Not with that face, with the other one. Ladies, be so kind. Decorate the portrait with flowers.

(Pavel kneels on all fours with the portrait glued to his rear end. Tosya and Syusya place flowers around the portrait)

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Use white flowers, Tosya, white flowers. And make them forget-me-nots if you can. It will be symbolic.

ILINKIN. Stepan Stepanovich, why did you stand in front of us? My wife is a woman, you know. She can't see over your head.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. I believe that my services to the fatherland allow me...

ILINKIN. Stepan Stepanovich, what services to the fatherland?

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. My good sir, I am nothing less than an active counterrevolutionary.

ILINKIN. But what have you done, if I may ask?

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. For all you know, I may have called a communist "Mister" instead of "comrade" at a perilous moment. And what have you done?

ILINKINA. Petya, let him stand in front. Who knows, maybe he's telling the truth.

PAVEL. Help! I've been stabbed!

ALL. What happened?

PAVEL. Mama, they're making me into a pin cushion.

NADEZHDA. Ladies, if you can, please try to pin them to his pants and not to his body. If his pants get ruined, it's no great loss.

THE WARRANT — ACT III

AGAFANGEL. Your excellency, they are coming.

AVTONOM. As soon as they enter, everyone shout "Hurrah!"

SCENE THIRTY-THREE

(Enter the Hurdy-Gurdy Man, the Drummer and the Woman with a Parrot and Tambourine)

ALL. Hurrah!

AVTONOM. What the hell is this? Who are you?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. We are guests, my good man, guests.

AVTONOM. Whose guests?

DRUMMER. Your guests, my good man, your guests.

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Olimp Valerianovich was kind enough to invite us to the wedding, and so, as you can see, we have arrived.

ANATOLY. They're probably the musicians.

AVTONOM. Say, do you happen to know the kind of music that is played at court?

WOMAN WITH A PARROT AND TAMBOURINE. What a strange question, my good man. We've been playing in courtyards our whole life.

AVTONOM. In that case, stand over here.

TOSYA. Mama, look how pretty the symbol came out.

AGAFANGEL. Your excellency, they are approaching.

AVTONOM. Attention, gentlemen, attention. More gaiety, gentlemen, more gaiety.

VARVARA. Pavlusha, smile!

NADEZHDA. Pavlusha, when she walks past you, don't forget to ask her to give us a grocery store.

PAVEL. Mama, I can't ask from that side. You'd better ask her yourself.

AGAFANGEL. Her Highness, the Empress!

AVTONOM. Present arms! Attention! Music! Play the anthem!

SCENE THIRTY-FOUR

(Enter Nastya, Olimp, Valerian and Father Pavsikakhy)

ALL. Hur-r-r-ah!

PAVEL. Don't hang me, Your Highness. For God's sake, don't hang me!

NADEZHDA. Have mercy on him, Your Highness! He did it out of stupidity. Truly, he did it out of stupidity.

NASTYA. What are you clinging to my hem for? Oh my God, it's the mistress.

THE MAJOR PLAYS OF NIKOLAI ERDMAN

NADEZHDA. Oh my God, it's Nastya.

ALL. Hur-r-r-ah!

PAVEL. Mama, fan me with something or I'm going to pass away here in front of everyone.

OLIMP. Gentlemen. This day Her Royal Highness has graciously agreed to graciously enter into wedlock with my son Valerian Olimpovich.

VARVARA. Ah!

ALL. Hur-r-r-ah!

OLIMP. Dear ladies and gentlemen! I weep.

VARVARA. I do too.

NADEZHDA. Varya! Shut up!

AVTONOM. Dear ladies and gentlemen! Her Royal Highness thanks you for your hearty welcome. Dear ladies and gentlemen...

OLIMP. Your Royal Highness...

AVTONOM. Olimp, shut up a minute, will you? I'll keep it short.

OLIMP. For seven years I remained silent. I can remain silent no more. Seven years, Your Royal Highness, I have waited seven years for this day and finally it has come.

FATHER PAVSIKAKHY. Dear Christian believers, long shall ye live.

ALL. Long shall we live. Long shall we live.

AVTONOM. What in the world are you playing?

HURDY-GURDY MAN. Sorry about that. The key won't seem to stay in tune.

OLIMP. Your Royal Highness, what is the Russian intelligentsia? The Russian intelligentsia is an angel, an unseen angel soaring high above Russia. Please allow me, Your Royal Highness, to say a few words in the stead of this angel.

NASTYA. Hit it.

OLIMP. Seven years, Your Royal Highness, seven years our heads have been covered in filth. Seven years. And each one of them has seemed like a decade. But what am I saying? What decade? Each one of them has passed as though it were an entire century. Seven hundred years, Your Royal Highness, our heads have been covered with filth.

ALL. Bravo! Bravo!

OLIMP. And even when the white guard mixed the blood of its sons with the priceless blood of our martyred motherland, even then our heads were covered with filth. Even then we were accused of violence, we were accused of being predators, we were accused of executions. But I now stand face to face, eye to eye with the personification of all of Russia. And I say to her, "no." I shout with all my might, "Show us that man whom we executed! Let him come forth and accuse us. But he will never come forth, because he is not here."

ALL. Bravo! Bravo!

THE WARRANT — ACT III

OLIMP. Your Royal Highness, I bare before you my heart and I stand before you as naked as the day I was born.

SYUSYA. Papa! Bend over, I want to see!

OLIMP. And I say to you, "Yes." Yes, Your Royal Highness. Yes, we loved our people. Oh, Your Royal Highness, oh, how we loved our people! I, for example, devoted my entire life to the working people. I had a factory and there were five-hundred people working in it. And I loved those people. But they were taken away from me and I am prepared to die getting them back, because without those people I can't live. Your Royal Highness, give us back our people.

ALL. Give us back our people!

OLIMP. Yes, Your Royal Highness, we loved our people and we loved our land. But are they capable of loving? How could they love their people and their land when they have never owned either people or land? But I, Your Royal Highness, owned land. Lots of land. Almost a thousand acres of nothing but land. And they took it away from me. They deprived me of my wet-nurse, my mother and my mama.

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. Your Royal Highness, give us back our mama!

OLIMP. But most of all we loved Russia. And what do we see now? She is gone. They replaced her. They pulled her out from under our feet. And now we hang suspended in the air, Your Highness. I hang in the air as if I were weightless. Yes, Your Highness, we have been deprived of weight and we hang in the air, while beneath us there is no Russia to be seen for thousands and thousands of miles. What will we do if we suddenly plunge back to earth, Your Highness? There is nowhere for us to fall. But I believed, I always believed, Your Highness, that a new Columbus would appear and discover Russia. He has appeared, this Columbus, and this Columbus is you. The waves are still stormy, but our course is right. We have already heard the joyous cry of "land!" ring out from the mast. A thousand acres of it. My land.

FATHER PAVSIKAKHY. Dear Christian believers, save our native land!

ALL. We'll save our land! We'll save it!

AVTONOM. Music! Fanfare! Hurrah!

ALL. Hur-r-r-ah!

NASTYA. Wow! What a wedding!

ALL. Hur-r-r-ah!

(When the cheer dies down, a long shriek is heard)

VOICES. Did you hear that? What was that? What was that?

NASTYA. Oh my God, that was probably Ivan Ivanovich screaming in terror in the next room.

OLIMP. Gentlemen, perhaps the people are already celebrating.

THE MAJOR PLAYS OF NIKOLAI ERDMAN

ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Do you think they already know?

OLIMP. Of course they know. Why else would they start shouting "hurrah"?

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. Are you sure they were shouting "hurrah"?

OLIMP. I heard it as plain as day.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Then the people are with us! Hurrah!

ALL. Hur-r-ah!

OLIMP. Listen.

VOICE OF IVAN. Help!

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. Did you hear anything?

AVTONOM. No. Did you?

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. Me either.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. Let's try again.

ALL. Hur-r-r-r-a-a-h!

OLIMP. Listen.

AVTONOM. The people are silent.

NASTYA. God help us if they ever try to have their say again.

PAVEL. Women, men and even children! Take note of the terrible hero standing before you!

VOICES. What happened? What was that? What's going on?

PAVEL. Women, men and even children! This dame has her sights set on the throne. But she will mount it only over my dead body. That is my absolutely official declaration to you.

VOICES. What is he saying? Is he insane? Your Highness, he's insane.

PAVEL. Comrades. What did we, workers of the plough, and chairmen of housing committees, struggle for? Why did we fall as victims on the blood-red battlefields? Women, men and even children, I refuse, I categorically and heroically refuse to swear loyalty to the social order of generals, priests and petty bourgeoisie.

VOICES. Don't let him speak! Make him shut up!

PAVEL. Comrades. No one can make us remain silent about this. Forever, we will speak in unison about generals, priests and the petty bourgeoisie because this is our idea. It is our holy obsession. Women, men and even children, you will not be able to strangle the revolution as long as we are here..., that is, me and my mama. And don't you think that it's only her that I'm not afraid of. Nothing of the sort. I can go to England and I won't even fear the English Queen. I'll tell off any tsar there is. And don't think that kings will avoid my wrath just because they are far away. Comrades, I am a man of enormous scope. This very instant, in fact, I declare before all tsars, be they English, Italian, Turkish or French, "Tsars!...", mama, what's going to happen next?!... "Tsars!... You're all... rapscallions!"

AVTONOM. Gentlemen, it's a plot. Arrest him immediately.

VOICES. Arrest him! Arrest him!

NASTYA. Leave him alone. He's drunk.

THE WARRANT — ACT III

AVTONOM. Your word is law for me, Your Highness, but...

PAVEL. Drunk? Who's drunk? I'm drunk? I could breathe in any man's face right now and he wouldn't smell a thing. That is the whole point, comrades, I am dead sober. The point is that I am capable of this even when sober. And I demand that you fix for posterity the words I am about to say, because, for having said them, I may be in for a promotion. Your Imperial Highness, you... are a bitch.

ALL. A-h-h!

NASTYA. The same goes for you.

AVTONOM. Guards!

AGAFANGEL. Yes, your excellency.

AVTONOM. Seize him!

VOICES. Seize him! Tie him up!

PAVEL. Comrades! She's a cook. As God is my witness, a cook!

NADEZHDA. Good sirs, she is a cook. Honest. A cook.

VARVARA. It's Nastya the cook.

THE THREE GULYACHKINS. A cook!

AVTONOM. What?

PAVEL. Respected comrades, she is our cook.

AVTONOM. Silence!

PAVEL. Honest, she's a cook. She used to wash my socks and fry meatballs. I'm telling the truth.

OLIMP. There is no doubt about it. He's insane.

NADEZHDA. My dear people, it's God's truth. She fries our meatballs.

Nastya, you slut, answer your mistress. Do you fry our meatballs or not?

NASTYA. Doubtlessly.

NADEZHDA. Did you hear that, good people? She admitted it. She admitted it as if on God's tribunal.

OLIMP. Your Highness...

NADEZHDA. Who's Highness is she? Her name is Pupkina. I even have her papers with me. Pupkina. Anastasiya Nikolayevna Pupkina.

OLIMP. Pupkina?

NADEZHDA. Pupkina. From the town of Povetkino in the province of Tula.

OLIMP. Your Imperial Highness, what does this mean, "Pupkina"?

NASTYA. Nothing in particular.

VALERIAN. Pupkina?

NASTYA. Pupkina.

OLIMP. And your uncle?

NASTYA. What about him?

OLIMP. Do you have an uncle?

NASTYA. Yes.

OLIMP. A duke?

NASTYA. What do you think, we're foreigners or something?

THE MAJOR PLAYS OF NIKOLAI ERDMAN

OLIMP. Who is he then?

NASTYA. A sexton.

OLIMP. Hold on to me! Hold me! Gentlemen, I think I'm going to rise up into the air again.

ZOTIK FRANTSEVICH. That's it. All is lost.

NARKIS SMARAGDOVICH. The renaissance is over.

OLIMP. You mean, once again, nothing exists? Neither she, nor I, nor you?

PAVEL. Comrades. You're right about that. There's nothing anywhere. But my words live on. My heroism, comrades, remains. No one can ever deny the fact that I called the heiress to the Russian throne a bitch. Do you realize what my potential is? For having said something like that they might start letting me enter the Kremlin without a pass. They might build a sanatorium in the name of Pavel Gulyachkin. Comrades, do you really think that just because they took away my grocery store and tore down the sign on it that they destroyed me along with them? No comrades. I'm willing to hang out a new sign and I'll bargain under it with everything of value in the world. I'll sell anything, I don't care what it is.

VOICES. Comrade Gulyachkin, don't ruin us! He's the one to blame. He's the one.

PAVEL. Aha, my little dears! So you're scared are you? You think that if you go turning my rear end into a mini picture gallery that I'm going to thank you for it, do you? You think you can turn a man's face inside out and that I'm going to remain silent about it? No, my dears. No. I'll destroy all of you. All of you!

VOICES. Don't ruin us! Have mercy! We don't want to die for nothing!

PAVEL. Silence! Do you know what I'm capable of? When I get an idea in my head, I'm capable of anything. For the sake of an idea, I made myself into a dowry. And now I'll marry Varya off to all of Russia! Varya! Pick any one you want.

NADEZHDA. Go on, Varya. Pick somebody.

VOICES. Me! Choose me! Over here!

VARVARA. I want a passionate man in a pince-nez.

FELTSIATA GORDEYEVNA. My husband! Choose my husband!

TOSYA. Choose my papa!

OLIMP. Ladies and gentlemen, what is going on here? I saw it all with my own eyes. Right here on this very spot. Our passionately beloved motherland, our rough-hewn Mother Russia rose like a Phoenix from a trunk.

STEPAN STEPANOVICH. What trunk?

OLIMP. Avtonom. Anatoly. Bring in the trunk.

(They carry in the trunk)

THE WARRANT — ACT III

Ladies and gentlemen, I was standing right here.
AVTONOM. And I was right here.
VALERIAN. And I was over here, holding a muffin.
ANATOLY. And I was by the cactus.
AVTONOM. And I opened the lock.
OLIMP. And Russia rose before us.
IVAN. (*Appears out of the trunk with the pot on his head*) I heard and saw everything.

(*All shriek and scatter*)

Comrades. Keep your wits about you and don't go far because all of you are going to be hung.
VOICES. Save us, Pavel Sergeyevich! Save us, Pavel Sergeyevich! Tell him, Pavel Sergeyevich! Pavel Sergeyevich!
IVAN. Police! Police! Police!
OLIMP. Excuse me, comrade. What do the police have to do with this?
IVAN. I'm going to report you.
OLIMP. What are you going to report?
IVAN. That right here in your own apartment, right here in this dining room, you have overthrown the Soviet government.
NASTYA. Vanya, quit your blathering.
OLIMP. Comrade, it just seemed that way, honest. It's not true. We have witnesses. Here's a communist, for instance.
IVAN. Where's there a communist?
OLIMP. Right here, Pavel Sergeyevich.
IVAN. Pavel Sergeyevich? I'll have you know, citizens, that Pavel Sergeyevich is a False Dmitry and an imposter. He's no communist.
PAVEL. Who's a False Dmitry? I'm a False Dmitry? Me? Comrades! I am a people's tribune. I have callouses. Look at the callouses on my hands. But that's not all. You should see the callouses I have on my feet!
IVAN. You're lying!
PAVEL. I'll prove it.
IVAN. How?
PAVEL. You just call Chicherin² in here and ask him whether I'm a communist or not, comrades.
AVTONOM. You're taking a big risk, citizen. He has a warrant.
IVAN. Where's his warrant?
PAVEL. Right here. (*Removes it from his briefcase*)
IVAN. (*Grabs the piece of paper*) You've all had it now, citizens.

² Georgy Chicherin was a prominent figure in the Communist Party and the People's Commissar of Foreign Affairs.

THE MAJOR PLAYS OF NIKOLAI ERDMAN

PAVEL. Grab him! Grab him! Where are you going? Where are you going?
IVAN. To the police, citizens, to the police. (*Runs out*)
PAVEL. Help! Help!
ALL. Help! Help!
PAVEL. I'm done for. They'll hang me, hang me for certain.
OLIMP. What would they hang you for? Can a person like you really be hung, comrade?
PAVEL. True Christian believers, I composed that warrant myself.
VARVARA. Give my regards to mama. I'm dying.
OLIMP. Yourself? What do you mean, yourself? But you're a communist, aren't you?
PAVEL. No, comrades. I'm basically...
OLIMP. Basically what?
PAVEL. Basically, I'm a man of many profiles.
OLIMP. It's over. All is lost. There are no real people. She's not real and he's not real. Maybe we're not real, either?
AVTONOM. Unreal people is one thing, but what do you do when warrants are phony?
ARIADNA PAVLINOVNA. Comrades, I can't be arrested. I have children. See? My little bunnies Tosya and Syusya.
FATHER PAVSIKAKHY. I'm the next best thing to a party member because Jesus Christ was a communist.
PAVEL. Mama, tell them I'm a fool. Tell them I'm stupid. Maybe they don't hang idiots, mama.
NADEZHDA. They won't believe me, Pavlusha. They won't believe me.
PAVEL. Oh yes they will, mama. As God is my witness, they will.
VOICES. They're coming! Oh Lord! Oh my God! We're ruined! We're done for!
OLIMP. Sisters and brothers, we shall suffer for the truth.
VALERIAN. Papa, I think I'm going to be sick.
OLIMP. Just like the first Christians.

(*Pause*)

SCENE THIRTY-FIVE

(*Enter Ivan. He sits on a chair and weeps*)

OLIMP. What's wrong? What happened?
IVAN. They refused.
OLIMP. Refused what?
IVAN. They refused to arrest you.

THE WARRANT — ACT III

(Pause)

PAVEL. Mama, if they don't even want to arrest us, how are we going to live? Mama, how are we going to live?

THE END